

When "Ping" Is No Longer Duckweed:
Conceptual Suspension and the Broken Cognitive Contract of
Academic Knowledge Production
——And a Discussion of Why "Experts" Say Things That Defy Common Sense

Guorui He
Independent Researcher

Author email: NooEcology@outlook.com

ORCID: 0009-0006-2947-0032

Personal Repository (GitHub): <https://github.com/wenhe1994/wenhe001>

Abstract

In recent years, the figure of the "expert" has fallen from authority to mockery in public discourse. Existing explanations—that experts are out of touch, that they serve vested interests, that the media quotes them out of context—capture fragments of the phenomenon but fail to reveal its underlying mechanism.

This essay offers a different diagnosis. The problem lies not in the moral failings of individual scholars, but in a systemic drift within the cognitive structure of academic knowledge production itself.

I call this drift *conceptual suspension*. Conceptual suspension occurs when an academic concept, passed down across generations, retains its stable name while its precise meaning drifts through the cumulative erosion of its unfolding path. Consider a thought experiment. The first generation of scholars uses the Chinese character "苹" (*píng*) to refer to duckweed—a small green plant floating on water, roots suspended beneath. They write this definition down. The second generation cites the term without repeating the definition. By the fifth generation, scholars still use "苹" in grammatically correct, logically coherent sentences. But if you ask them what exactly it refers to, they may answer, "a kind of drifting state, perhaps?" The signifier remains. The signified has drifted. This is conceptual suspension.

This essay argues that the root of conceptual suspension is the *hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy* of the academic community.

The original function of the academic community is to produce and disseminate reliable knowledge in service of the cognitive development of individuals within the host system—society at large. Its legitimacy derives from the public, the ultimate users of knowledge, through their scrutiny and acceptance. Yet public scrutiny faces a double barrier. First, conceptual suspension inflates the cognitive cost of access, turning academic papers into black boxes impenetrable to outsiders. Second, existing institutions have concentrated the power of verification in the hands of peers and capital. The public—especially those directly affected by the application of knowledge (the delivery rider scheduled by an algorithm, the resident relocated by urban planning, the patient guided by a medical protocol)—lacks any institutionalized channel to feed their lived experience back into academic knowledge production.

Here one must address a key defense: does not industry-academic collaboration already provide a channel for verification?

This essay's response is that industry verifies *technical efficacy* (Does this knowledge solve a specific technical problem? Can it generate profit?), but it cannot substitute for the verification of *social validity* (Does this knowledge genuinely promote the survival and flourishing of individuals within the host system?). The arbiter of technical efficacy is capital; the arbiter of social validity is the people. When the channel for verifying social validity is absent, the self-organization tendency of the academic community naturally drifts toward those nodes that offer the most immediate resources for survival: the peer circle, the state apparatus, and capital. Conceptual suspension is the cognitive signature of this hollowed-out anchor: scholars are no longer accountable to a public that "doesn't understand," only to peers and funders.

This essay further argues that blaming scholars for "obfuscation" or demanding that all papers be written for a popular audience both miss the mark. The genuine path forward lies in breaking the monopoly on verification and rebuilding the cognitive contract between the academic community and the public. This essay proposes two concrete institutional pathways: (1) opening a *practice-based verification channel*, allowing those who actually use knowledge to report on the social validity of published claims in real-world contexts—not a public vote on the quality of papers, but a mechanism for the lived experience of affected parties to become admissible evidence; and (2) opening a *public submission channel*, allowing

knowledge producers excluded by the academic credentialing system to submit research that is filtered by practical verification rather than peer review alone. This is not a rejection of peer review or industry verification, but the restoration of a healthy *antagonistic structure* within academic knowledge production—ensuring that knowledge is tested not only by capital, but also by the people.

The writing of this essay attempts to exemplify what it advocates. Each of its core concepts is introduced with an unfolding interface that connects it back to everyday experience. It assumes no prior internalization of academic jargon. It invites every reader to put its argument to the test: can the claims of this essay withstand the scrutiny of your own lived experience?

Keywords: conceptual suspension; anchor of legitimacy; academic community; cognitive contract; peer review; practical verification

A Note on Terms, Genre, and Theoretical Background

I. Glossary of Core Terms

This essay employs a number of specialized terms in the course of its argument. Most are drawn from the author's broader theoretical framework of System Ontology and Noetic Ecology, but each is introduced in the text with an unfolding interface that connects it back to everyday experience. What follows is a concise index for quick reference. You may consult it here or absorb the terms as they arise in context.

- **Conceptual Suspension**

The phenomenon whereby an academic concept, transmitted across generations, retains its stable signifier (its name) while its signified (its precise meaning) drifts through the cumulative erosion of its unfolding path. The thought experiment of the Chinese character "萍" (*píng*) provides an intuitive illustration: initially referring to duckweed, it eventually signifies little more than "a drifting state." The name remains; the referent has drifted.

- **Anchor of Legitimacy**

The ultimate validator to which a subsystem's legitimacy is moored—the agent capable of defining the subsystem's mode of self-organization through the exercise of its rights. For the academic community, its original anchor of legitimacy is the public. When the public's power of verification is institutionally bypassed, the anchor is hollowed out.

- **Unfolding Path / Unfolding Interface**

The cognitive chain that traces a specialized concept back to the experiential problem and everyday phenomenon to which it was originally anchored. A healthy concept preserves this path; a suspended concept severs it. An *unfolding interface* is a deliberate opening left by the writer—a concrete example, an analogy, a statement of origin—that allows the reader to step back down to the ground of lived experience.

- **Technical Efficacy vs. Social Validity**

Technical efficacy refers to a piece of knowledge's effectiveness in solving a specified technical problem. Its typical arbiter is the enterprise. *Social validity* refers to the composite impact of that knowledge on the social members affected by its application. Its arbiter should be those affected parties themselves (consider the relationship between an efficiency algorithm and the delivery riders it governs). A central claim of this essay is that verification by enterprise cannot substitute for the verification of social validity.

- **Self-Organization Tendency**

The inherent propensity of any system to maintain and expand itself. The academic community possesses its own self-organization tendency—it will naturally gravitate toward serving those nodes that provide the most immediate resources for its survival.

- **Functional Differentiation and the Reification Fallacy**

The error of mistaking the functionally differentiated organs of a civilizational host (such as the state, capital, or the academic community) for independent external entities. This essay draws upon this theorem to argue that the academic community and the public belong to the same civilizational host, and that the former's responsibility to the latter is the intrinsic responsibility of an organ to the body, not an externally imposed demand.

- **Practice-Based Verification Channel**

One of the institutional designs proposed in this essay. An open platform, parallel to existing

academic journals, where practitioners affected by the application of knowledge can submit verification reports, providing evidence of a knowledge claim's social validity in real-world contexts.

- **Public Submission Channel**

The second institutional design proposed. A channel that breaks the credential monopoly on academic publication, allowing anyone who follows basic scholarly norms to submit a paper and have it filtered by practical verification rather than peer review alone.

II. A Note on Genre and Method

This essay deliberately adopts a genre that has become increasingly rare in contemporary academic writing.

Its defining features are:

1. **It begins from a problem, not from the literature.**

The driving force of this essay is a publicly observable puzzle—"Why have experts become a term of derision?"—rather than the filling of a scholarly gap.

2. **Terms are defined in context.**

Every specialized term, upon its first appearance, is accompanied by an unfolding interface that connects it back to everyday experience. You can grasp its meaning through a thought experiment (the journey of the character "苹"), an engineering analogy (the accumulation of error), or an observable phenomenon (the delivery rider and the algorithm).

3. **You are invited to pause and test at any moment.**

If any claim in this essay strikes you as dubious, you are encouraged to test it against your own lived experience. If it fails that test, the failure belongs to the essay, not to the reader.

The writing of this essay attempts to exemplify what it advocates. An essay diagnosing *conceptual suspension* that is itself written in suspended concepts would be self-refuting. An essay arguing that knowledge should be subject to public scrutiny that is itself written in a language impenetrable to the public would be self-negating. This essay therefore assumes no prior internalization of academic jargon. It does not rely on any term whose meaning has not been unfolded. It does not mistake opacity for profundity.

This is not antiquarianism. It is a requirement of the argument itself.

III. Relation to the Theoretical Framework

This essay draws upon axioms and theorems from the author's broader theoretical framework of System Ontology and Noetic Ecology. To avoid interrupting the main line of argument, only brief explanations are provided in the body of the text. For readers who wish to trace these concepts further, their full provenance is noted here.

The theoretical framework consists of the following works:

- **System Ontology** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19353224) — The meta-theoretical layer, providing the ultimate jurisprudence of existence and the axiomatic foundation. The axioms cited in this essay—Axiom 3 (Self-Organization Tendency), Axiom 6 (The Criterion of Human-Centered Value), and Axiom 7 (The Principle of Functional Derivation)—originate here. The newly introduced **Theorem 8 (Functional Differentiation and the Reification Fallacy)**, derived during the writing of this essay, will be incorporated into future revisions of *System Ontology*.
- **Noetic Ecology** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19353340) — The general theoretical layer,

investigating the laws of cognitive, cultural, and social systems as *noetic systems*. The diagnosis of "conceptual suspension" developed in this essay is a specific application of the theory of "noetic genes" to the domain of academic knowledge production.

- **Civilization Dynamics** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19353434) — The applied theoretical layer, extending Noetic Ecology to the scale of civilizational diagnosis and design. The institutional designs proposed in Chapter 7 (the practice-based verification channel and the public submission channel) are concrete instantiations of the discrete antagonistic structures described in the "System Topology" section of that work.
- **Introduction to Cognitive Protocols** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19448172) — An entry-point work that deduces the origins of core theoretical concepts from the consensus foundations of semiotics, information theory, systems theory, and cognitive science. Readers seeking to understand how concepts like "self-organization tendency," "cognitive framework," and "noetic gene" are derived from existing disciplinary knowledge will find the complete deductive path in this volume.

All works are freely available at the author's personal repository: <https://github.com/wenhe1994/wenhe001>

Important Note: This essay introduces **Theorem 8: Functional Differentiation and the Reification Fallacy**, a new theorem derived by the author from the axiomatic system of System Ontology during the writing of this essay. It is not yet included in the currently released version of *System Ontology*. Chapter 5 of this essay provides a self-contained statement of the theorem's core meaning sufficient for the argument. The full formal statement and deduction of the theorem will be incorporated into subsequent revisions of *System Ontology*.

This essay does not require the reader to accept this theoretical framework in advance. The axioms and theorems cited here can be treated as *working hypotheses*—their validity is guaranteed not by the authority of their source system, but by their explanatory power within this essay. If the diagnosis and pathways proposed here help you make sense of the phenomenon of "experts becoming brick-throwers" and offer actionable ideas for reforming academic knowledge production, then these theoretical tools will have fulfilled their purpose. If, after reading, you arrive at a different diagnosis or a better solution, that is precisely the conversation this essay most hopes to provoke.

1. Introduction: Starting from "Experts Becoming Brick-Throwers"

1.1 A Pervasive Puzzle

In recent years, a curious phenomenon has taken root in public discourse. The figure of the "expert"—once a byword for authority and reason—has become an object of derision, a punchline. In Chinese, the term has even morphed: *zhuānjiā* (专家, expert) is now mockingly rendered as *zhuānjiā* (砖家, "brick-thrower" or "brick-expert"), a homophone that suggests someone whose opinions are as solid as a thrown brick.

Open any social media platform and the examples proliferate. An economics professor advises low-income households that they might "rent out their idle properties." An education specialist counsels young people not to "fixate on starting salaries." An urban planning scholar proposes "improving traffic efficiency by reducing the number of bus stops." Each such pronouncement is met with a wave of public anger, mockery, and profound bewilderment.

This bewilderment cuts both ways. The public wonders: these people have received the finest education, they have read more books than anyone—how can they say things that so flagrantly defy common sense? The experts, for their part, are equally perplexed: my recommendations are theoretically defensible; why does the public not only reject them, but respond with such visceral antipathy?

Existing explanations tend to fall into three categories.

The first holds that experts are "out of touch," sequestered in ivory towers and ignorant of the real conditions of ordinary life. This captures something of the phenomenon but fails to explain its mechanism. Why would academic training not prevent this estrangement, but rather seem to exacerbate it?

The second explanation points to experts "serving vested interests," suggesting that their pronouncements are driven by capital or power. This accounts for some cases but fails to explain why so many "brick-throwing" statements seem to serve no one's interest at all—why would a scholar supposedly shilling for real estate developers suggest that the poor "rent out idle properties," a remark even developers would find absurd?

The third explanation blames the media for "quoting out of context," arguing that experts' complete arguments are truncated and distorted in transmission. Again, this explains only a subset of cases. It fails to address a deeper phenomenon: even when we locate and read the original paper or monograph in its entirety, the public still finds it impenetrable—still feels excluded by a closed linguistic system.

This essay attempts a fourth explanation. One that does not appeal to the moral failings of individual scholars, nor stop at the distortions of media transmission. It asks a more fundamental question: has the cognitive structure of academic knowledge production itself undergone a systemic drift?

1.2 The Central Thesis

The central thesis of this essay is that contemporary academic knowledge production is marked by a pervasive phenomenon that I call *conceptual suspension*. Conceptual suspension occurs when an academic concept, passed down across generations, retains its stable signifier while its signified drifts through the cumulative erosion of its unfolding path. The consequence is that academic knowledge gradually loses its anchoring connection to everyday experience, becoming a closed system of signs that refer only to one another.

Let me illustrate with a thought experiment.

Imagine the first generation of scholars faced a concrete problem: how to describe the small green plant that floats on the surface of southern Chinese paddy fields, its roots hanging vertically in the water,

drifting with the current yet never losing its place. They chose the Chinese character "萍" (*píng*) to name it. In their writings, they clearly defined it: "萍: an aquatic floating plant, leaves small, roots suspended in water. Commonly found in rice paddies and ponds."

At this point, the signifier "萍" possesses a precise signified—a specific plant. Its unfolding path is clear: concept name ("萍") → definition → experiential phenomenon (the small green floating plant) → original problem (how to describe this particular plant). Any reader can trace this path from the abstract term back to concrete, lived experience.

The second generation of scholars works on similar problems of plant ecology. They cite the term "萍" without repeating the definition—an entirely reasonable practice. Efficiency demands that we need not rebuild every concept from the ground up.

By the fifth generation, the situation has changed. This scholar is not working on aquatic plant taxonomy at all. She is trying to describe a cultural phenomenon—say, how a tradition maintains its identity while adapting to changing historical currents. The term "萍" surfaces in her mind: floating on the surface, drifting with the current yet keeping its roots in place. A perfect metaphor. She writes: "Traditional culture is like floating *píng*, carried along by the river of history yet always preserving its roots."

The sentence is elegant. The logic is coherent. But if you now ask this fifth-generation scholar what exactly "萍" refers to, she might hesitate. She knows it is some kind of aquatic plant—perhaps she can recall "floating," "green," "small leaves." But she can no longer say with precision whether the original "萍" was duckweed or watershield, four-leaf clover or water hyacinth. She may never have seen the plant with her own eyes. Her understanding of "萍" is no longer anchored to the concrete experiential phenomenon that the first generation fixed. It is anchored instead to the *usage* of the sign in successive texts—a broad, fuzzy semantic field: "something aquatic, drifting, indeterminate."

The signifier remains. The signified has drifted.

This is conceptual suspension.

This diagnosis leads to a deeper question: why has the academic community failed to detect and correct this drift?

This essay's answer is that the *anchor of legitimacy* of the academic community has been hollowed out. The original function of the academic community is to produce and disseminate reliable knowledge in service of the cognitive development of individuals within the host system—society at large. Its legitimacy derives ultimately from the public, the users of knowledge, through their scrutiny and acceptance. Yet when the power of evaluation is entirely monopolized by peers, and when the public—especially those directly affected by the application of knowledge—lacks both the cognitive interface to access knowledge and the institutional channel to feed back their lived experience, the self-organization tendency of the academic community naturally drifts toward those nodes that offer the most immediate resources for survival: the peer circle, project funders, and capital in industry-academic collaborations. Conceptual suspension is the cognitive signature of this hollowed-out anchor: scholars are no longer accountable to a public that "doesn't understand"; they are accountable only to peers and funders.

1.3 Relation to Existing Explanations

How does this diagnosis relate to the three common explanations?

Compared to the "out of touch" narrative, this essay asks *how* this estrangement occurs at the cognitive level. It is not that scholars subjectively disdain connecting with ordinary life; it is that the very structure of knowledge production no longer requires them to anchor concepts in everyday experience.

Compared to the "serving vested interests" narrative, this essay does not deny the role of interests. But it

argues that the pursuit of interest is a *consequence* of the hollowed-out anchor, not the root cause. Scholars drift toward capital not necessarily out of moral corruption, but because the anchor chain to the public has loosened, and capital offers the most secure alternative mooring. Compared to the "media misquotation" narrative, this essay acknowledges media distortion but locates the root problem not in the transmission link, but in the production link. If concepts are already suspended, even verbatim quotation by the media will not enable the public to penetrate the terminological fog.

1.4 The Argumentative Path

This essay proceeds in six steps.

Step one (Chapter 2) formally introduces the diagnosis of *conceptual suspension*. Using the thought experiment of "苹" and the engineering analogy of error accumulation, it precisely defines conceptual suspension and distinguishes it from the linguistic notion of semantic drift.

Step two (Chapter 3) analyzes the mechanism by which conceptual suspension occurs. It traces the historical drift in academic writing from a "problem-first" to a "literature-first" paradigm, showing how unfolding paths are severed and how error accumulates across generations.

Step three (Chapter 4) investigates the root cause of conceptual suspension. Introducing the concept of the *anchor of legitimacy*, it argues that the public's power of verification has been institutionally bypassed, hollowing out the anchor and driving academic knowledge production toward closure.

Step four (Chapter 5) establishes the criterion for why this is a problem. Drawing on the axiomatic framework of System Ontology, it argues that conceptual suspension is not merely a "regrettable phenomenon" but a systemic health problem that betrays the original function of the academic community.

Step five (Chapter 6) addresses key defenses of the status quo. It responds head-on to arguments about the necessity of terminology, the division of labor, and the role of industry-academic collaboration, showing that the conditions under which these defenses were once valid have systematically eroded.

Step six (Chapter 7) proposes pathways forward. It argues that repairing the cognitive contract requires not making all papers popular, but breaking the monopoly on verification—rebuilding institutionalized channels through which affected parties can test the social validity of knowledge, ensuring that knowledge is tested not only by capital but by the people.

1.5 A Note on the Writing of This Essay

Before proceeding, a word on the style of this essay.

This essay deliberately adopts a genre that has become increasingly rare in contemporary academic writing. Its defining features are these: each core concept, upon first appearance, is accompanied by an unfolding interface that connects it back to everyday experience; it assumes no prior internalization of academic jargon; it invites the reader to test every claim against their own lived experience.

This choice is not a matter of nostalgia. It is a requirement of the argument itself. An essay diagnosing *conceptual suspension* that is itself written in suspended concepts would be self-refuting. An essay arguing that knowledge should be subject to public scrutiny that is itself written in a language impenetrable to the public would be self-negating.

The writing of this essay therefore attempts to exemplify what it advocates. As you read, you are encouraged to pause at any moment and ask: What does this term mean? What phenomenon in my own life does it point to? Where is the anchor of this argument? If this essay cannot answer those questions, the failure belongs to the essay, not to the reader.

1.6 A Self-Test for This Essay

Before the argument fully unfolds, it is reasonable to address a foreseeable objection: does this essay, which criticizes conceptual suspension, itself constitute one grand exercise in conceptual suspension? After all, it proceeds not by experimental data but by logical deduction and phenomenological analysis. If the core concepts it deploys are themselves suspended, then its critique of the academic community would be self-refuting.

This essay submits itself to five tests, and invites the reader to be the judge.

First, do the core concepts of this essay possess clear unfolding paths?

The three central concepts—*conceptual suspension*, *anchor of legitimacy*, and *unfolding path*—are each introduced with an interface that connects them back to everyday experience: a thought experiment, an engineering analogy, an observable phenomenon. The reader can follow these interfaces back to the experiential referent of each concept.

Second, is the argument anchored in publicly observable phenomena?

The starting point of this essay—the phenomenon of "experts becoming brick-throwers," the reading experience of academic papers, the contrast between classical and contemporary writing paradigms—consists of phenomena that any literate person can verify for themselves. This essay's work is to provide a unified theoretical explanation for these phenomena, not to conjure a suspended conceptual system from thin air.

Third, has this essay preserved an interface for its own verification?

The institutional designs proposed in Chapter 7—the practice-based verification channel and the public submission channel—are themselves frameworks within which the claims of this essay can be tested. If these proposals prove ineffective in practice—if, for instance, opening verification channels fails to improve the cognitive contract between academia and the public—then the conclusions of this essay should be revised or abandoned.

Fourth, do the definitions of this essay's concepts rely on other suspended concepts?

The foundational concepts this essay employs (system, self-organization tendency, legitimacy) are drawn from the axiomatic system of System Ontology, which itself is anchored in the pattern recognition of cross-disciplinary boundary crises. Within the argument of this essay, the use of these concepts is self-consistent and traceable.

Fifth, is conceptual research necessarily suspended?

The writing of this essay serves as a counterexample. It does not rely on experimental data, yet by anchoring each concept in publicly observable phenomena, it demonstrates that non-empirical theoretical inquiry can be non-suspended. The root of conceptual suspension is not "the absence of experiment," but "the severance of the unfolding path." So long as a clear unfolding path is preserved, theoretical deduction can remain anchored to experiential ground.

If this essay fails any of these tests, the failure is the essay's, not the reader's. The reader is invited to continue this examination throughout.

Now, let us begin with that character: "苹."

2. Conceptual Suspension: A Diagnosis

This chapter formally introduces the core diagnostic concept of this essay: *conceptual suspension*. It proceeds in five steps. First, a thought experiment provides an intuitive grasp of the phenomenon. Second, a formal definition is given. Third, an engineering analogy clarifies the cumulative mechanism. Fourth, the concept is distinguished from the linguistic notion of semantic drift. Fifth, operational criteria for identifying conceptual suspension are proposed.

2.1 A Thought Experiment: The Journey of the Character "苹"

Let us begin with a simple thought experiment.

Imagine the first generation of scholars faced a concrete research problem: how to describe the small green plant that floats on the surface of southern Chinese paddy fields, its roots hanging vertically in the water, drifting with the current yet never losing its place. They needed a specific term to denote it. They chose the Chinese character "苹" (*píng*). In their writings, they solemnly inscribed the definition: "苹: an aquatic floating plant, leaves small, roots suspended in water. Commonly found in rice paddies and ponds of the south."

At this moment, the signifier "苹" possesses a precise signified—a specific plant. Its unfolding path is clear: concept name ("苹") → definition → experiential phenomenon (the small green floating plant) → original problem (how to describe this particular plant). Any reader, following this path, can travel from the abstract term back to the concrete ground of lived experience.

The second generation of scholars works on similar problems of plant ecology. They cite the term "苹." Because their predecessors' definition was clearly written, there is no need to repeat it in every paper. They assume readers know what the character refers to and proceed to use the concept in their own reasoning. This is entirely legitimate—efficiency requires that we not rebuild every concept from scratch. By the fifth generation, the situation has changed. This scholar is not working on aquatic plant taxonomy at all. She wants to describe a cultural phenomenon—say, how a tradition maintains its identity while adapting to changing historical currents. The term "苹" surfaces in her mind: floating on the surface, drifting with the current yet keeping its roots in place. A perfect metaphor. She writes in her paper: "Traditional culture is like floating *píng*, carried along by the river of history yet always preserving its roots."

The sentence is elegant. The logic is coherent. But if you now ask this fifth-generation scholar what exactly "苹" refers to, she might hesitate. She knows it is some kind of aquatic plant—perhaps she can recall "floating," "green," "small leaves." But she can no longer say with precision whether the original "苹" was duckweed or watershield, four-leaf clover or water hyacinth. She may never have seen the plant with her own eyes. Her understanding of "苹" is no longer anchored to the concrete experiential phenomenon that the first generation fixed. It is anchored instead to the *usage* of the sign in successive texts—a broad, fuzzy semantic field: "something aquatic, drifting, indeterminate."

The signifier remains. The signified has drifted.

This is conceptual suspension.

The signifier—the character "苹"—has been preserved intact. Sentences in papers are grammatically correct; logical deductions remain internally coherent. But the signified—the concrete experiential phenomenon to which the concept originally referred—has drifted across generations. The connection between concept and its original experiential ground still exists, in name. The cable remains attached.

But the anchor has been dragging along the seabed for a long time, far from where it was first dropped.

2.2 A Formal Definition of Conceptual Suspension

Based on the thought experiment above, we can now offer a formal definition:

Conceptual suspension is the phenomenon whereby a noetic gene (an academic concept), in the process of intergenerational transmission, retains its stable signifier while its signified undergoes cumulative drift due to the severance of its unfolding path, rendering the concept incapable of being traced back with precision to its original experiential anchor.

This definition contains several key elements.

First, the signifier remains stable. The name of the concept has not changed—"莘" is still "莘"; "self-organization" is still "self-organization"; "alienation" is still "alienation." This stability is precisely what allows conceptual suspension to remain concealed. On the surface, everything appears normal. Terminology is used in accordance with disciplinary norms; logical chains are intact. Without deeper probing, one would notice nothing amiss.

Second, the signified drifts. The experiential content to which the concept refers undergoes displacement across generations. This displacement is not sudden or dramatic; it is gradual and cumulative. Each generation of scholars deviates slightly from the previous one—perhaps a nuance of interpretation, perhaps an extension of application, perhaps a "creative appropriation" to suit a new problem context. Viewed in isolation, each generation's operation falls within a reasonable tolerance range. But after multiple generations of accumulation, the concept has drifted far from its original anchor.

Third, the unfolding path is severed. The unfolding path is the cognitive chain that traces a specialized concept back to the experiential problem to which it was originally anchored. The first generation establishes this chain: concept → definition → experiential phenomenon → original problem. Subsequent generations do not reconstruct this chain; they use the concept in its "packaged" form. Over time, the unfolding path is forgotten. The concept becomes a black box—you know the contexts in which it is used, you know which other concepts it pairs with, but you do not know its internal structure. You do not know what it actually refers to.

Fourth, precise traceability is lost. Conceptual suspension does not mean that the concept has entirely lost all connection to reality. If it had, the symbolic system would collapse immediately—papers would become utterly incomprehensible, experiments would fail to replicate, technological applications would break down. The subtlety of conceptual suspension lies in the fact that it preserves a broad, fuzzy semantic field. If you ask a scholar what "莘" refers to, they can say "some kind of aquatic plant, I think" or "a state of drifting, perhaps." This is sufficient to maintain the internal coherence of the terminological system, but insufficient to support precise experiential anchoring. The concept has become a *specter of the signifier*—it has a name, it has usage patterns, but it lacks a precise signified.

2.3 An Engineering Analogy: The Accumulation of Error

To grasp the mechanism of conceptual suspension more intuitively, we can borrow an analogy from engineering: the accumulation of error.

Imagine a first-generation engineer designs a custom part to solve a specific problem. On the blueprint, the dimension is marked as 10.00 millimeters. This dimension was precisely calculated based on the requirements, materials, and manufacturing processes of the time.

The second-generation engineer references this design and produces their own version. Due to measurement tolerances or slight process variations, the actual dimension of their part is 10.01

millimeters. A deviation of 0.01 millimeters falls within the specified tolerance range. It is fully acceptable in practice.

The fifth-generation engineer, working from the drawings passed down, produces a part measuring 10.03 millimeters. The tenth-generation engineer produces one measuring 10.10 millimeters.

At each step, the deviation falls within the tolerance range of the previous generation's drawing. Examined in isolation, each part is "qualified." But after ten generations, the part can no longer fit precisely into the system for which it was originally designed. Worse still, no one knows where the problem originated—because each generation faithfully replicated the drawings handed down to them. The transmission of academic concepts undergoes precisely this same accumulation of error.

The first generation of scholars precisely anchors the signified of a concept (10.00 millimeters, with full design documentation). The second generation introduces a tiny shift in usage (10.01 millimeters). The fifth generation possesses only a broad grasp of the concept's referent (10.03 millimeters). The tenth generation can no longer articulate what exactly the concept refers to (10.10 millimeters). Yet every generation's paper passes peer review. Every generation is deemed to have produced "normative academic writing."

This is what makes conceptual suspension so insidious: it requires no one to make a mistake.

Each generation of scholars does what is "correct" in their own immediate context—citation norms are followed, reasoning is rigorous, terminology is used in accordance with disciplinary convention. Yet the system as a whole progressively loses precision.

2.4 Distinguishing Conceptual Suspension from Semantic Drift

At this point, it is necessary to distinguish *conceptual suspension* from the existing linguistic concept of *semantic drift*.

Semantic drift is a phenomenon described in historical linguistics: the meanings of words naturally change over long periods of use. For example, the English word "silly" drifted from its Old English meaning of "blessed, happy" to "innocent, harmless," and eventually to "foolish." Semantic drift is a natural feature of language evolution. Linguistics studies it descriptively, without value judgment—semantic change in itself is neither "good" nor "bad."

Conceptual suspension bears a superficial resemblance to semantic drift: both involve diachronic change in meaning. But they differ in three crucial dimensions.

First, the domain of occurrence differs. Semantic drift occurs in the everyday use of natural language; it is an unconscious process in which the entire linguistic community participates. Conceptual suspension occurs within the specialized terminological system of an academic community; it is a systemic phenomenon arising from the conscious writing and citation practices of knowledge producers.

Second, traceability differs. Semantic drift typically lacks a clear "original definition" to which one can trace back. No one can say with certainty what the word "silly" originally meant or precisely when it began to change. But the birth of an academic concept is documented in the literature—the first generation's definition is written down in a paper. The problem with conceptual suspension is not that tracing is *impossible*, but that the tracing path is not preserved in the everyday use of the concept.

Third, normativity differs. Linguistics makes no normative judgment about semantic drift—it merely describes what is. But conceptual suspension is a *diagnostic* concept. It points to a systemic health problem that can and should be corrected. The original function of the academic community demands that it maintain the precision and traceability of its concepts. When conceptual suspension occurs, it is not the natural evolution of language; it is a departure of the knowledge-production system from the

cognitive standards it ought to uphold.

Conceptual suspension is therefore not a simple mapping of semantic drift onto the academic domain. It is a pathology specific to academic knowledge production, rooted in the unique power structures and incentive systems of the academic community.

2.5 Operational Criteria for Identifying Conceptual Suspension

How can one determine whether a concept has become suspended? Three operational questions can serve as diagnostic tools.

Question 1: Can the person using the concept point, in ordinary language, to the experiential phenomenon it refers to?

This is the most direct test. If a scholar can only explain the concept by invoking another, equally abstract term—producing a *concept of concepts* ("alienation is the estrangement of the subject from its own essence")—but cannot point to a concrete experiential case ("a worker tightening bolts on an assembly line, not knowing what the final product is—that is a manifestation of alienation"), then the concept is likely suspended.

Question 2: Can the concept be traced all the way back to the specific problem it was originally created to solve?

Every academic concept was created to address a concrete problem. If contemporary users cannot say what original problem the concept was meant to solve, or can only vaguely state that "it is a foundational concept in the field," then the unfolding path has been severed.

Question 3: Does the definition of the concept rely on another concept that is itself equally suspended?

If one explains A in terms of B, B in terms of C, and C in terms of A—forming a closed definitional loop in which none of the links can be traced back to an experiential anchor—then the entire conceptual chain has become suspended. This is the typical manifestation of conceptual suspension at the level of a terminological system. It has a phenomenological name: *the concept of concepts*. "Concept of concepts" refers to a characteristic operation of suspended academic writing: explaining concepts with other concepts in a self-referential loop, with no link ever touching experiential ground. It floats like a ring of signs in midair, spinning freely, anchored nowhere.

If a concept simultaneously fails to be explicable in ordinary language, fails to be traceable to its original problem, and relies on other suspended concepts for its definition, then it can be diagnosed as suspended.

2.6 Chapter Summary

This chapter has formally introduced the core diagnostic concept of *conceptual suspension*. We presented the intuitive form of the phenomenon through the thought experiment of the character "苹," provided a formal definition, and clarified its cumulative mechanism through the engineering analogy of error accumulation. We distinguished conceptual suspension from the linguistic notion of semantic drift, establishing its unique status as a systemic diagnostic concept, and proposed three operational criteria for its identification.

In the next chapter, we will delve into the mechanism by which conceptual suspension occurs. Why has academic writing drifted from a "problem-first" to a "literature-first" paradigm? How are unfolding paths

severed? And how does error accumulate across generations?

3. The Mechanism: How Conceptual Suspension Occurs

In Chapter 2, we introduced the diagnosis of *conceptual suspension*, provided its formal definition, and proposed criteria for its identification. We must now ask a deeper question: how does conceptual suspension actually occur?

It is not the result of anyone's deliberate design, nor the sudden moral collapse of a particular generation of scholars. It is a systemic, intergenerationally cumulative cognitive drift. This chapter traces the historical shift in academic writing paradigms, analyzes how unfolding paths are severed, and explains how error accumulates across generations.

3.1 Two Writing Paradigms: Problem-First and Literature-First

To understand the mechanism of conceptual suspension, we must first distinguish two paradigms of academic writing.

Paradigm One: Problem-First.

This is the characteristic feature of classical academic writing. A researcher confronts a genuine perplexity—a phenomenon repeatedly encountered in life, experiment, or practice that cannot be grasped with existing concepts. To understand and describe this phenomenon, they create (or redefine) a concept. Because the concept is new, they must elaborate in their writing: where does this concept come from? What experiential phenomenon does it point to? What problem is it meant to solve?

We can find countless examples in intellectual history.

When Darwin introduced "natural selection" in *On the Origin of Species*, he did not assume readers already knew what the term meant. He began with the practice of pigeon breeders—how people had cultivated astonishingly diverse breeds through selective breeding. Then he asked: could a similar mechanism of "selection" operate in nature? From this concrete, observable experience, he gradually built up the theoretical concept of natural selection. Any reader, even without a background in biology, could ascend the staircase he laid down.

When Freud introduced "the unconscious" in *The Interpretation of Dreams*, he too began from his own dreams—a specific, narratable experience—and then progressively introduced concepts like "manifest dream," "latent dream," and "censorship."

When Weber, in *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, started from a seemingly narrow historical question—why did capitalism first emerge in Western Europe?—and then unfolded a series of concepts: "calling," "inner-worldly asceticism," "rationalization." The common feature of these classic works is that at the moment of their birth, their concepts carried clear staircases down to everyday experience.

Paradigm Two: Literature-First.

Contemporary academic writing—especially in the humanities and social sciences—increasingly exhibits a different character. The researcher confronts not an original experiential perplexity, but the texts left by predecessors. Their task is not "to solve a problem I have personally encountered," but "to fill a gap in the literature." And what is a "gap in the literature"? It is a point that previous texts have not adequately addressed, or where contradictions exist among them.

Under this paradigm, concepts are not grown from experience but inherited from literature. The researcher need not redefine concepts; they need only "use" them—placing them in appropriate positions according to disciplinary convention, combining them with other concepts in compliant ways. The introduction of a paper is no longer "I encountered this perplexity," but "Existing research has shown... however... therefore this paper attempts to..." The unfolding path of a concept—from which experiential problem it originally grew—is no longer necessary. Because peers all know (or are presumed to know) what the concept means. The paper becomes a kind of compliant operation within an existing terminological system.

The literature-first paradigm has its rationale in specialization and efficiency. It allows researchers to enter academic conversations quickly, without having to define all concepts from scratch every time. But its cost is that the unfolding paths of concepts are gradually forgotten. When generation after generation of researchers learn concepts only from literature and no longer return to the original experiences to which those concepts were anchored, the connection between concept and experiential ground grows ever more tenuous.

3.2 The Severance of the Unfolding Path

The "unfolding path" is another core concept we must introduce. It refers to the cognitive chain that traces a specialized concept back to the experiential problem and everyday phenomenon to which it was originally anchored.

A healthy concept possesses an unfolding path that looks like this: concept name → formal definition → operational indicators or experiential cases → original problem. From any link, you can trace upward or downward along the chain.

Take "natural selection" as an example. If you ask a biologist what "natural selection" means, they might first give a formal definition: "heritable variation leading to differential survival and reproduction, resulting in directional changes in population gene frequencies." If you press further—"Can you give an example?"—they can immediately cite Darwin's finches and their beak shapes, antibiotic resistance in bacteria, or the color changes of peppered moths during industrial melanism. If you ask further still—"What original problem was this concept created to solve?"—they can tell you: Darwin observed on the Galápagos Islands that finches on different islands had dramatically different beak shapes; he needed a mechanism to explain the source of this adaptation. From concept name to formal definition, from formal definition to experiential cases, from experiential cases to original problem—this path is clear and traceable.

Conceptual suspension occurs precisely when this unfolding path is severed.

The first form of severance: the loss of experiential cases. The researcher can state the formal definition of the concept but cannot provide a concrete, vivid example. Their definition is "term for term"—explaining the concept using another equally abstract concept. If you insist, "Can you give an example in ordinary language?" they hesitate, or offer an extremely vague, highly simplified "textbook case" that may bear little relation to the phenomena actually studied.

The second form of severance: the forgetting of the original problem. The researcher knows what the concept "is" and roughly how it "is used," but does not know what original problem the concept was created to solve. It has become a "foundational concept" that simply exists—like addition and subtraction in mathematics, which one only needs to know how to use, not their historical origins. But academic

concepts differ from mathematical operations. The meaning of mathematical symbols is entirely conferred by axioms and operational rules; they need not be anchored in experience. Academic concepts—at least those that describe the empirical world—derive their legitimacy precisely from their explanatory power with respect to experience. When the original problem is forgotten, the concept loses its tension with the experiential world. It becomes a self-sufficient sign, usable in compliant ways within papers, but no longer bearing the function of "explaining reality."

The third form of severance: definitional circularity. Concept A's definition relies on concept B; concept B's definition relies on concept C; concept C's definition circles back to concept A. In this closed loop, no link ever touches experiential ground. This definitional circularity is internally coherent within the terminological system—one can write a paper fully compliant with academic norms, with all terminology used "correctly." But if you try to exit the loop and ask, "What experiential phenomena do these concepts ultimately refer to?" you will find no exit. This is precisely the phenomenon we named in Chapter 2: *the concept of concepts*.

3.3 Intergenerational Error Accumulation

The severance of the unfolding path explains the static structure of conceptual suspension. But to understand why it occurs so pervasively within the academic community without being detected, we must introduce a dynamic mechanism: intergenerational error accumulation.

Let us return to the engineering analogy of error accumulation.

The first-generation engineer designs a custom part and precisely marks the blueprint: diameter 10.00 mm, material 45# steel, tolerance ± 0.02 mm. The design documentation explains why this dimension was chosen and how it relates to other parts in the system. The second-generation engineer produces a part based on this drawing; due to measurement limitations or slight process variations, the actual dimension is 10.01 mm—within tolerance, fully qualified. Their own drawing now marks "diameter 10.01 mm," but they do not include the original design rationale—to them, this is a standardized part requiring no repeated explanation. The fifth-generation engineer works from a drawing showing 10.03 mm. The tenth-generation engineer produces a part measuring 10.10 mm.

At each step, the deviation falls within the tolerance range of the previous generation's drawing. Examined individually, each part is a "qualified product" relative to its own generation's design. But after ten generations, the part no longer fits the system for which it was originally designed. Worse, no one knows where the problem originated—because each generation faithfully executed the drawings handed down to them. The original design intent has been lost in transmission.

The transmission of academic concepts undergoes the exact same accumulation of error.

The first generation precisely anchors the signified in their paper and thoroughly documents its experiential source and problem background. This is "10.00 mm, with full design documentation." The second generation cites the concept and applies it to a slightly different context—a legitimate application, since concepts should have some elasticity in their scope. But they do not repeat the definitional honesty and explanatory consciousness of the first generation. The signified undergoes a minute displacement—perhaps from "duckweed" to "floating plant." This is "10.01 mm, within tolerance." The fifth generation learns the concept from the literature but no longer sees the first generation's original definition. They see only the various ways predecessors have used the concept. They synthesize these usages and distill a "standard meaning"—but this meaning is already a statistical average, not the original anchor. This is "10.03 mm, because that's what the drawings say." The tenth generation uses the concept proficiently,

but if you ask what exactly it refers to, they can only offer a broad semantic field: "It's, you know, that kind of state..." This is "10.10 mm, won't fit but no one knows why."

The crucial point is that at each step, the operation was "correct." The second generation had no obligation to repeat the first generation's full definition in every citation—that would bloat papers intolerably. The fifth generation, synthesizing the "standard usage" from their reading, was doing what academic training normally does. The tenth generation used the concept according to disciplinary convention, and their paper passed peer review. At no point did anyone "make a mistake." Yet the system as a whole progressively lost precision.

This is the most unsettling feature of conceptual suspension: it is the cumulative consequence of *correct* operations. It requires no conspiracy, no laziness, not even any subjective malice. It requires only one condition: each generation is accountable only to the immediately preceding generation, not to the original experiential anchor.

3.4 Why Has the Academic Community Not Detected This?

If conceptual suspension causes academic concepts to gradually lose experiential precision, why has the academic community internally failed to detect and correct it?

The answer is that conceptual suspension does not cause the internal coherence of the system to collapse. A suspended concept can still form logically rigorous propositions within the terminological system. Scholars can skillfully manipulate these concepts, write compliant papers, and engage in spirited debates at academic conferences. The sentences are grammatically correct, the reasoning steps are complete, the citation formats are proper. Peer reviewers—themselves trained in the same terminological system—can understand what the paper is saying and judge whether it "makes a contribution."

Suspended concepts resemble an internally coherent chess game. You can play brilliant moves on the board; all the rules are observed, all the moves have names. But if you ask a chess player, "What was the original purpose of the knight's move—what did it simulate?" they might be stumped. They don't know, and they don't need to know—they only need to know that the knight moves in an "L" shape. The everyday use of academic concepts increasingly resembles this kind of board operation. The meaning of a concept is determined by its function within the rule system, not by its referential relation to the external world. So long as the rule system is internally coherent, operations can continue indefinitely.

It is only when these concepts are placed under the sunlight of everyday experience that their suspended nature is exposed. When a journalist presses, "What exactly does that term mean?" When a policymaker requests, "Explain it in terms I can understand." When an interdisciplinary collaborator asks, perplexed, "In our field, that word means something else." In these moments, the symptoms of conceptual suspension become visible. But the academic community is rarely placed in such situations. The institution of peer review ensures that scholars need only be accountable to those who already understand the terminological system.

As for the public's bewilderment, it has been sealed off entirely outside the academic walls.

3.5 Can Empirical Research Claim Immunity?

Before proceeding to the next chapter, we must address a reasonable objection: does the foregoing analysis apply primarily to theoretical research in the humanities and social sciences? Are empirical disciplines—those that run experiments, collect data, and interact directly with the material world—naturally immune to conceptual suspension?

The answer is that empirical research *inhibits* the most extreme forms of conceptual suspension, but

cannot eradicate it.

The operationalization procedures of empirical research do impose a kind of "forced anchoring" on concepts. When a researcher must operationalize "organizational commitment" as "scores on an employee retention intention questionnaire," they are forced to establish an explicit correspondence between the concept and observable indicators. If their chosen indicator is manifestly unreasonable (e.g., using "how many cups of coffee the employee drinks per day" to measure organizational commitment), peer reviewers will object. This methodological constraint prevents, to some degree, the complete suspension of concepts—one cannot define concepts arbitrarily; one must provide operational, testable definitions.

But operationalization is itself an act of translation. And translation inevitably entails drift.

When a theoretical concept is operationalized into measurable indicators, the researcher must make choices: which dimensions of the concept are retained, and which are discarded? Consider "alienation." Marx used it to describe the worker's fourfold separation—from the product of labor, from the labor process, from their own species-being, and from other human beings. This is a holistic existential experience, heavily value-laden. Later empirical researchers operationalized it into measurable components: "job satisfaction," "occupational burnout," "organizational commitment," "sense of meaninglessness." These indicators can be administered via questionnaires, yield data, and undergo statistical analysis. They bear some relationship to Marx's original concept of alienation. But do they fully capture its entire meaning? Probably not. A worker may be "satisfied" with their job (the pay is decent, colleagues are friendly) yet still be alienated in Marx's sense—their labor is merely a means of subsistence; they cannot realize their creative potential in work. The operationalization captures "satisfaction" but may lose "alienation."

This is not a failure of operationalization. Operationalization is an indispensable step in empirical research. But it does introduce minute displacements each time a concept "touches down" in measurement. When generation after generation of researchers fine-tune existing operationalizations without returning to the concept's original problem, conceptual suspension still occurs. Its form is no longer "pure symbolic play detached from all experience," but rather "the gradual dilution of a concept's original experiential core through successive generations of operational translation."

A deeper problem remains: empirical research anchors itself to *technical efficacy*, not *social validity*.

This is a point that will be elaborated later in this essay, but a brief preview is warranted here. An algorithmic model can be A/B tested to confirm that it improves delivery efficiency. This is a test of technical efficacy, and empirical methods are fully capable of it. But whether this algorithm causes delivery riders to speed recklessly, increases traffic accidents, or decouples labor intensity from income—these dimensions of social validity are not within the A/B testing framework. It is not that empirical methods have been "done wrong"; it is that the dimension of verification has been institutionally narrowed. When research is funded by enterprises and the testing criteria are set by enterprises, technical efficacy becomes the only systematically verified dimension. Social validity—those consequences that cannot be quantified as corporate profit metrics—becomes a blind spot of verification.

Empirical research, therefore, does not grant a discipline immunity from conceptual suspension. It merely alters the form that conceptual suspension takes: from the symbolic play of "concepts of concepts" to the "dilution of meaning through operational translation" and the "institutional narrowing of verification dimensions."

3.6 Chapter Summary

This chapter has analyzed the mechanism by which conceptual suspension occurs. We distinguished two paradigms of academic writing—"problem-first" and "literature-first"—and argued that the latter leads to the systematic severance of the unfolding paths of concepts. We borrowed the engineering concept of error accumulation to illustrate how conceptual suspension accumulates across generations: each generation does what is "correct," yet the system as a whole progressively loses precision. We explained why the academic community internally fails to detect this: suspended concepts remain internally coherent within the terminological system. Finally, we addressed the objection that empirical research might be immune, showing that while it inhibits extreme forms of suspension, it cannot eradicate it—the dilution of meaning through operational translation and the institutional narrowing of verification dimensions are the characteristic forms of conceptual suspension in empirical disciplines.

In the next chapter, we will probe the deeper root of conceptual suspension: why do the incentive structures and power configurations of the academic community systematically permit, even encourage, the severance of unfolding paths? We will introduce the core concept of the *anchor of legitimacy* and analyze the historical drift of the academic community's foundation of legitimacy.

4. The Root: Hollowing Out the Anchor of Legitimacy

In the preceding three chapters, we described the phenomenon of conceptual suspension, provided its formal definition, and analyzed the surface mechanism by which it occurs—the paradigm drift from "problem-first" to "literature-first" writing, and the accumulation of intergenerational error. Yet a fundamental question remains unanswered: why has the academic community failed to correct this drift? If a system persistently produces outcomes that deviate from its original function, normal system dynamics would predict some negative feedback mechanism to pull it back on course. Why does this negative feedback seem to have failed in academic knowledge production?

This chapter offers a deeper diagnosis: the *anchor of legitimacy* of the academic community has been hollowed out.

The anchor of legitimacy is the ultimate validator to which a subsystem's legitimacy is moored—the agent capable of defining the subsystem's mode of self-organization (how the system operates and makes decisions) through the exercise of its rights. When the anchor of legitimacy is secure, the subsystem must continuously respond to the needs of the anchoring agent; otherwise, it loses legitimacy. When the anchor is hollowed out, the subsystem's self-organization tendency (its inherent propensity to maintain and expand itself) begins to drift. Its internal quality standards and incentive structures gradually detach from the original function and gravitate toward serving those nodes that offer the most immediate resources for survival.

For the academic community, its original anchor of legitimacy is the public—the ultimate users of knowledge, whose scrutiny and acceptance ground its legitimacy. Yet in the contemporary academic apparatus, the public's power of verification has been institutionally and systematically bypassed. Conceptual suspension is the cognitive signature of this hollowed-out anchor.

4.1 The Anchor of Legitimacy: An Analytical Tool from System Dynamics

Before unfolding the specific analysis, we must first introduce the concept of the *anchor of legitimacy* and ensure that it possesses its own clear unfolding path.

4.1.1 An Intuitive Grasp of the Anchor of Legitimacy

Imagine a ship. The ship has its own power system—an engine and a propeller—that enables it to sail autonomously. This corresponds to the *self-organization tendency* of a subsystem (the inherent propensity of any system to maintain and expand itself): it operates continuously, requiring no external push. But the power system is responsible only for "forward motion," not for "direction." Without a navigation mechanism, the ship will gradually drift off course under the influence of wind, currents, and mechanical error. This is not because the crew or the captain has "become corrupt"; it is simply that any autonomous navigation system inevitably faces directional drift.

Therefore, the ship needs a navigation system to determine its heading and to continuously correct deviations between its actual position and its intended course. This navigation system is the ship's "anchor of legitimacy." Its function is not to propel the ship forward (that is the power system's job), but to ensure that the direction of motion does not deviate from the original mission.

A social subsystem—whether the academic community, a medical institution, the media, or a government—is like this ship. It possesses a self-organization tendency (the power system) and operates autonomously. But it also needs an "anchor of legitimacy" (the navigation system)—an external reference capable of verifying whether its operation has deviated from its original function and of exerting corrective force when deviation occurs. This reference is the *exercise of rights* by the subsystem's intended beneficiaries. The beneficiaries are able to define the course of the subsystem (the social functional entity) and to send corrective signals when the subsystem drifts.

When beneficiaries can effectively exercise this right, the navigation system functions normally: the subsystem continuously receives feedback from those it serves and dynamically adjusts its course. When beneficiaries, due to cognitive barriers or institutional absence, are unable to exercise this right, the navigation system fails. The ship's power system continues to run; the ship continues to move forward. But it no longer heads toward its original mission. It begins to drift with the currents, heading toward the path of least resistance—toward those nodes that offer the most immediate resources for survival.

This is the hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy. It is not that the ship has stopped; it is that the ship is moving, but the navigation system has been disabled.

4.1.2 The Original Anchor of the Academic Community

What is the original function of the academic community? According to **Axiom 7: The Principle of Functional Derivation** from System Ontology, the legitimacy of any social subsystem derives from its service to the overall health of the host system, in accordance with its original function. The academic community, as the functional subsystem responsible for "knowledge production and dissemination" within the civilizational host, has an original function that can be stated as follows: *to produce and disseminate reliable knowledge, enhancing the cognitive capacity and action efficacy of individuals within the host system.*

Who judges whether this function is being fulfilled? Not the academic community itself. Just as the quality of a restaurant's food cannot be judged solely by the chef, the judge must be the users of the knowledge—the public within the host system. Whether a farmer who adopts a new cultivation technique sees increased yield, whether a physician who applies a new treatment protocol improves patient outcomes, whether a citizen who understands a public policy can make more informed voting decisions—the ultimate criterion for these tests lies in the lived practice of the public.

Therefore, the original anchor of legitimacy of the academic community is the public. Its legitimacy is founded on the continuous scrutiny and acceptance of knowledge products by the public. This scrutiny does not require the public to peer-review the mathematical proofs in a paper; it requires that the effects

of knowledge in application—both its technical efficacy and its social validity—be subject to feedback from those affected.

4.2 The Hollowing Out of the Anchor: A Double Barrier

If the public is the anchor of legitimacy for the academic community, what has happened to this anchor chain in the contemporary academic apparatus? The diagnosis of this essay is that public scrutiny of academic knowledge faces a double barrier. The first barrier inflates the cognitive cost of access; the second barrier blocks the channel for feedback. Together, they result in the systematic hollowing out of the anchor.

4.2.1 The First Barrier: Conceptual Suspension Inflates Cognitive Costs

This is the argument that the preceding three chapters have already elaborated. Here, we offer a concise synthesis.

For the public to scrutinize a knowledge product, they must first be able to understand what that product is saying. This does not require the public to comprehend every technical detail of a paper; it does require that the "interface" of the knowledge be clear—what the core concepts refer to, what experiential problem they arose from, what typical phenomena they correspond to in reality.

Conceptual suspension systematically undermines this comprehensibility. When academic concepts gradually lose their anchoring connection to everyday experience across generations, papers become black boxes impenetrable to the public. What the public faces is not knowledge that is "difficult but learnable," but a labyrinth of signs with no discernible entry point. The cognitive cost is inflated to an unreasonable degree, and vast swaths of the public are excluded at the first barrier.

It must be emphasized that this does not imply that all academic papers should be written as popular science. Specialized knowledge production inevitably involves terminology and formalized expression. But specialization does not require severing the unfolding path. Healthy specialized terminology should be like a tree: one can follow the trunk (everyday experience) along the branches (conceptual hierarchy) all the way to the leaves (cutting-edge research). What conceptual suspension causes is a rupture between the trunk and the branches—concepts can no longer be traced back to everyday experience. This rupture is the result of the academic community failing to fulfill its responsibility in packaging knowledge.

4.2.2 The Second Barrier: The Institutional Narrowing of Verification

Even if the public overcomes the first barrier—even if some member of the public possesses sufficient cognitive capacity to understand a piece of research—they still face a second barrier: they lack any institutionalized channel to feed the results of their scrutiny back into academic knowledge production. The power of verification in the contemporary academic apparatus is highly concentrated at two nodes: *peers* and *capital*.

Peer review verifies the *internal validity* of research—whether the methods are rigorous, the reasoning coherent, the evidence sufficient. This is necessary, but it is not sufficient. Peer review cannot verify the *social validity* of knowledge—whether the application of knowledge in the real world genuinely promotes the survival and flourishing of individuals within the host system. Peers can judge whether a paper is "competent by disciplinary standards"; they cannot judge whether this knowledge is "beneficial to the people."

Industry-academic collaboration verifies *technical efficacy*—whether knowledge can be transformed into profitable technologies, products, or services. Enterprises fund academic research and

simultaneously serve as "users" who test the effectiveness of research outcomes. This verification channel genuinely exists and has value. But it possesses a fatal blind spot: the enterprise's criterion of verification is profit, not social validity. A technology may be highly efficient and profitable for the enterprise, yet cause harm to the workers, communities, or environments it affects. The delivery algorithm is the paradigmatic case: the algorithm is impeccable in technical efficacy (reducing delivery time, increasing platform profit), but its social validity—the accident rate among riders, the stability of their income, their labor autonomy—is entirely invisible within the enterprise's verification framework. The crucial question here is: *where is the verification channel for those social members directly affected by the application of knowledge—the riders, residents, patients, workers?*

The answer is that there is none. In the current academic apparatus, no institutionalized interface exists for a delivery rider to feed back the lived experience that "this algorithm makes my work more dangerous" to the scholars who research algorithms. No channel exists for a resident to convey the objection that "this planning scheme ignores our old neighborhood" to the urban planning researcher. No channel exists for a worker to communicate the feeling that "this management theory has become more refined surveillance on the shop floor" to the professor of organizational behavior.

The power of verification has been institutionally narrowed. Peers verify internal validity. Capital verifies technical efficacy. The verifier of social validity—the people—has been excluded from the verification apparatus.

4.2.3 Distinguishing Two Kinds of Verification: Technical Efficacy and Social Validity

To avoid conceptual suspension ourselves, we must precisely define the terms "technical efficacy" and "social validity."

Technical efficacy refers to the effectiveness of a piece of knowledge or technology in solving a specified problem. The verifier is the user of the knowledge—typically an enterprise or other application-oriented institution. The criteria of verification are quantifiable metrics such as efficiency, cost, performance, and profit. Verification of technical efficacy is necessary; it ensures that knowledge is not empty talk.

Social validity refers to the composite impact of a piece of knowledge or technology, in the course of its application, on other components of the host system—especially those individuals who are affected by its application but have no power to participate in decision-making. The verifiers are those social members directly affected by the application of knowledge. The criterion of verification is the human-centered value criterion established by **Axiom 6**: *Does this knowledge promote the survival and flourishing potential of every individual within the host system?*

The verifier of technical efficacy is the enterprise. The verifier of social validity is the people. When the verification channel for the latter is absent, the academic community's anchor of legitimacy is left with only the enterprise and the peer circle. And both the enterprise and the peer circle—as subsystems—have their own self-organization tendencies. They will not proactively substitute for the people in verifying social validity, because doing so does not serve their own survival interests.

This is the precise meaning of the hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy: it is not that the anchor has disappeared, but that *the anchor has been replaced*. The legitimacy of the academic community ought to be moored to the people, but in the institutional operation, the people have been substituted by the enterprise and the peer circle. The academic community is no longer accountable for "whether the public benefits," only for "whether peers approve" and "whether enterprises provide funding."

4.3 The Dynamic Consequences of a Hollowed-Out Anchor

When the anchor of legitimacy is hollowed out, the self-organization tendency of the academic community drifts. This is not moral corruption; it is a systemic inevitability.

First, the internalization and involution of incentive structures. The survival of scholars depends on the approval of peers. The metrics of peer approval—number of papers, citation counts, journal rankings—become the core or even sole criteria of academic evaluation. These metrics have no necessary connection to "whether the public benefits." A highly cited paper may be entirely useless, even harmful, to society. But under a regime with a hollowed-out anchor, this does not affect a scholar's career prospects. The incentive structure drives scholars to devote their energy to "how to gain peer approval," rather than "how to make knowledge serve the public." Conceptual suspension is the cognitive product of this incentive structure: when the goal of writing is "to be recognized as an insider by peers" rather than "to be understood by the public," unfolding paths become superfluous encumbrances. Clear definitions, accessible examples, and anchoring to everyday experience—these appear "too simple" or "insufficiently professional" to peers, yet they are precisely the interfaces the public needs.

Second, the singularization of verification criteria. When the enterprise becomes the primary "client" of academic knowledge, technical efficacy overwhelms social validity. This is not because the enterprise is "evil"—the enterprise is faithfully executing its own self-organization tendency (the pursuit of profit). The problem is that when the enterprise becomes the most important patron of the academic community, the agenda and evaluation criteria of academic research inevitably tilt toward directions that yield technical efficacy and attract enterprise funding. Research that offers no commercial value but is crucial for social validity—such as the impact of delivery algorithms on riders' working conditions, or the long-term effects of social media on adolescent mental health—is marginalized due to lack of a "client."

Third, the rupture of the feedback loop. A healthy system requires negative feedback to correct its course. When the application of knowledge produces negative social validity, the suffering of affected parties ought to constitute a negative feedback signal, prompting the academic community to adjust its research direction or revise its theoretical models. But when affected parties lack an institutionalized feedback channel, this signal never reaches the knowledge producers. The academic community races ahead on the single dimension of technical efficacy, utterly unaware of the accumulating deficit in social validity—until the storm of public opinion erupts with cries of "experts are brick-throwers." Yet this storm of public opinion is crude and emotional; it cannot substitute for fine-grained institutional feedback. It can only express anger; it cannot transmit concrete information for correction.

4.4 Addressing a Key Defense: Does Not Industry-Academic Collaboration Already Provide Verification?

Before advancing to the next chapter, we must directly address a recurring defense.

Defense: The academic community is not sequestered in an ivory tower. The extensive collaboration between industry and academia—the integration of production, teaching, and research—demonstrates that academic knowledge is being tested in practice. The enterprise, as a representative of the "public," is already exercising the power of verification.

Response: This defense conflates two kinds of verification. The enterprise verifies *technical efficacy*; it cannot substitute for the verification of *social validity* by affected parties.

The enterprise is an organizational form of capital. Its self-organization tendency is the pursuit of profit. When an enterprise tests a piece of academic knowledge, it tests whether that knowledge can help the enterprise produce more efficiently, market more precisely, or compete more effectively. This is an entirely legitimate form of verification, and it is a necessary link in translating academic knowledge into productive forces. But the enterprise is not an agent of the people. The interests of the enterprise and the interests of affected parties are, in many cases, non-overlapping or even in conflict.

The delivery algorithm improves delivery efficiency; the enterprise benefits. The algorithm suppresses rider income and increases accident risk; riders are harmed. The enterprise has no incentive to test the latter—unless compelled by law or public pressure. But law and public opinion are external constraints, not internal feedback mechanisms within the academic community. The academic community cannot outsource the responsibility for "verifying social validity" to the enterprise and then assume that it has been taken care of. The original function of the academic community demands that it be directly accountable for the flourishing of individuals within the host system, not through the mediation of capital. Therefore, industry-academic collaboration is not the *completion* of verification, but the *localization* of verification. It narrows "the public" to "the enterprise" and "social validity" to "technical efficacy." The diagnosis of the hollowed-out anchor points precisely to this narrowing: it is not that there is no anchor, but that the anchor has been replaced.

4.5 Chapter Summary

This chapter introduced the *anchor of legitimacy* as an analytical tool from system dynamics and argued that the deep root of conceptual suspension is the hollowing out of the academic community's anchor of legitimacy. We distinguished two kinds of verification—technical efficacy and social validity—and showed that public scrutiny of academic knowledge faces a double barrier: conceptual suspension inflates cognitive costs, and the institutional narrowing of verification blocks feedback channels. When the enterprise substitutes for the people as the primary verifier, the self-organization tendency of the academic community drifts—incentive structures involute, verification criteria become singular, and feedback loops rupture. Conceptual suspension is the cognitive signature of this hollowed-out anchor. In the next chapter, we will establish the criterion for why this diagnosis is not merely an "interesting observation" but a systemic health problem that must be confronted.

5. The Criterion: Why This Is a Problem

In the preceding four chapters, we described the phenomenon of conceptual suspension, analyzed its mechanism, and traced its deep root to the hollowing out of the academic community's anchor of legitimacy. Yet a fundamental question remains unanswered: *by what criterion is this a problem at all?* Any diagnosis of the status quo must make its value criterion explicit. Without one, a diagnosis risks being dismissed as mere subjective preference—you think it's a problem, I don't, and the argument goes nowhere. Regarding conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor, a foreseeable defense is this: the academic community is *supposed* to be a specialized, autonomous domain. That the public finds it difficult to understand is normal, just as a patient finds a doctor's prescription difficult to understand. If this is normal, then conceptual suspension is not a problem, but an inevitable cost of specialization. A further defense might go: the host system that the academic community serves is the state; it serves the public indirectly by serving the state (through technological progress, talent cultivation, etc.). Therefore, it need only be accountable to the state, not directly to the public.

This chapter's task is to respond to these defenses and establish the criterion for why this is a problem. We will proceed in three steps. First, we introduce two axioms from System Ontology and argue that they reveal *factual regularities* of systemic persistence, not normative exhortations. Second, we introduce Theorem 8 to argue that the academic community and the public belong to the same civilizational host as functional organs and substrate components, and that the former's responsibility to the latter is an intrinsic requirement of systemic health, not an externally imposed demand. Third, we apply these criteria to argue that conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor signify the *alienation* of the academic community—an objective problem of departure from original function and damage to the health of the host system.

5.1 The Factual Nature of the Criteria: What Do Axioms 6 and 7 Reveal?

Axiom 6 of System Ontology states:

The persistence of any social system depends on its ability to continuously satisfy the specific needs of its internal components, thereby maintaining their coordinated participation in the system. Systemic value is expressed as the efficacy of its response to the needs of its components.

Axiom 7 states:

The sole legitimacy for the emergence and existence of any subsystem within a social system derives from its original function of serving the overall health of the host system.

Before proceeding with the argument, a crucial clarification is necessary: these two axioms reveal *factual regularities*, not *normative exhortations*.

A "factual" statement describes *what is*—how a system in fact operates, persists, and collapses. A "normative" statement expresses *what ought to be*—a moral command, a value choice.

Axiom 6 is not a moral slogan that "the system ought to serve the people." It is a factual description of system dynamics: a system that persistently fails to respond to the needs of its components will, through component exit, passive participation, or active resistance, decline toward collapse. This is not moral punishment; it is a law of survival. Just as a person who persistently fails to eat will starve—not because of a moral imperative that "one ought to eat," but because of the objective regularities of human metabolism.

Similarly, Axiom 7 describes the dynamical condition for the existence of a subsystem: the very existence of a subsystem is constituted by the function it performs within the host system. The heart exists because it pumps blood. If the heart ceases to pump blood, it loses its qualification to exist *as a heart*—not by moral condemnation, but by functional failure. The academic community exists because the civilizational host requires an organ to perform the function of "knowledge production and dissemination." When it ceases to perform this function effectively, it does not vanish immediately (systems have inertia), but its health continuously declines—manifested concretely as loss of trust, erosion of social esteem, and atrophy of resource supply. Eventually, it either self-corrects or is replaced by new forms of knowledge production.

Therefore, when this essay claims that conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor are "problems," it is not expressing moral indignation. It is stating a systemic diagnosis: *the academic community is undergoing health decline due to departure from its original function*. This is like a physician saying "your blood pressure is elevated"—not a condemnation of your lifestyle, but a warning that if the condition persists, your cardiovascular system faces heightened risk of failure.

5.2 The Direction of the Criterion: Why Should the Academic Community Be Accountable to the

Public?

Axioms 6 and 7 establish the factual nature of the criterion. But they do not directly answer a crucial question: what exactly *is* the "host system" that the academic community serves? Is it the state, or is it the public?

A powerful defense runs as follows: the host system of the academic community is the state. Academic institutions are established or accredited by the state; their funding is allocated by the state; their research agendas respond to national strategic needs; their talent cultivation serves national construction. Therefore, the academic community need only be accountable to the state, and the state in turn represents the public—a chain of indirect accountability. If this defense holds, then conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor are no longer problems, because the academic community need only ensure that its knowledge products are understandable and verifiable by its "client"—the state. Industry-academic collaboration and the integration of production and research are precisely manifestations of this service model.

To respond to this defense, we must introduce a new theorem from System Ontology.

Theorem 8: Functional Differentiation and the Reification Fallacy

In any noetic system that has reached a certain degree of complexity, there exist no "external entities" independent of the host system. All phenomena identified as "capital," "the state," "the market," "social organizations," "unions," "media," and so forth, are functional differentiations that have emerged from the host system, driven by the self-organization tendency, to fulfill specific functional needs. They are *organs* of the host system, not external invaders or independent game-players.

This theorem is not yet included in the currently released version of *System Ontology*; it is a new theorem derived by the author from that axiomatic system during the writing of this essay. Readers consulting that work will not find the original text; this note serves as clarification. The axioms on which it depends include: Axiom 2 (Material/Noetic Duality—every system presents simultaneously as material entity and noetic pattern), Axiom 3 (Self-Organization Tendency—the inherent propensity of systems to maintain and expand), and Axiom 6 (Duality of Levels—the coexistence of substrate and emergent levels). Its core meaning is this: those grand entities that public discourse treats as independent game-players—the state, capital, the market, the media—are in fact all functionally differentiated organs of the *same* civilizational host, emerged to fulfill specific functions. Their relations are not "confrontations between external entities," but "coordination and antagonism among organs within a single living body."

Let us use a biological analogy to grasp this. The human body's circulatory system, respiratory system, immune system, and nervous system—these are all products of functional differentiation. Each performs a specific function, each has its own operational regularities, and each can develop pathologies (alienation). But we would never say that "the circulatory system is an entity independent of the human body," nor would we ask "should the nervous system be accountable to the body or to the circulatory system?" They are all organs of the body, and their criterion of health is unified: *do they promote the survival and flourishing of the entire organism?*

The civilizational host is no different. The state is an organ that the civilization has differentiated to fulfill the functions of order maintenance and collective action coordination. Capital is an organ differentiated to fulfill the functions of resource allocation and production organization. The academic community is an organ differentiated to fulfill the function of knowledge production and dissemination. The public (the people) is not another "organ"; it is the *substrate components* that constitute the entire civilizational host. The ultimate purpose of all organs is to serve the survival and development of these substrate components. Therefore, the question "should the academic community be accountable to the state or to capital?" is a

wrongly posed question. The correct question is: *as a functional organ of the civilizational host, does the operation of the academic community promote the survival and development of the host's substrate components—the public?* The state, capital, and the academic community are all organs that serve the public. When the interests of the state align with those of the public, serving the state *is* serving the public. But when the state, as an organ, undergoes drift in its self-organization tendency (Axiom 3) from "serving the public" toward "self-maintenance," serving the state is no longer equivalent to serving the public. At such a moment, if the academic community continues to be accountable only to the state, it degrades from being the "knowledge organ of civilization" to being an "appendage of the state organ." It no longer serves the host body, but another organ that may itself be equally alienated.

This is why the academic community must be directly accountable to the public. Not out of moral elevation, but because the public is the ultimate substrate to which the legitimacy of all organs is moored. The state is an organ; capital is an organ; the academic community is an organ. The public is not an organ; the public is the body itself. Organs can be accountable to other organs (this is necessary for division of labor and coordination), but organs must ultimately be accountable to the body. When the chain of accountability between organs and the body's needs is severed, the organs drift toward alienation.

Corollary 8.1 (The Reification Fallacy) precisely diagnoses the cognitive root of the defense that opened this section: treating "the state" and "the academic community" as two independent entities and then asking "which should be accountable to which?" This very way of posing the question is a product of reification. In the perspective of System Ontology, they are functionally differentiated organs of the same civilizational host; their relation is not "a game between external entities," but "coordination and antagonism among internal organs." The criterion of health is not defined by any single organ, but by the whole of the host body—that is, by the survival and development of the public.

5.3 How the Two Criteria Define the "Problem"

We can now answer with precision: *by what criterion are conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor problems?*

First, from the perspective of Axiom 6 (factual regularity), conceptual suspension inflates the cognitive cost for the public to access knowledge, and the hollowed-out anchor blocks the channel for the public to verify social validity. Together, they systematically undermine the contribution of academic knowledge to the survival and development of the host's substrate components—the public. The public's feeling that "experts are out of touch" and "academic papers are unreadable" is not a result of laziness or ignorance, but a consequence of the academic community—as an organ—failing to fulfill its function of responding to the needs of substrate components. When public trust in experts collapses—when "brick-thrower" becomes a popular epithet—this is itself a signal from the substrate components that "needs are not being met." According to Axiom 6, a subsystem that persistently fails to respond to the needs of its components will, through loss of trust, resource atrophy, and talent flight, decline toward collapse. This is not a moral curse; it is a prediction of system dynamics.

Second, from the perspective of Axiom 7 (functional derivation), the original function of the academic community is to serve as the knowledge organ of the civilizational host—to produce and disseminate reliable knowledge, enhancing the cognitive capacity of the substrate components. When the power of verification is narrowed to a closed loop of peers and capital (two organs that may themselves be alienated), the self-organization tendency of the academic community drifts from "serving the host body"

toward "serving adjacent organs." This is not a moral failing of individual scholars; it is a systemic inevitability once the anchor is hollowed out. But the result of this drift is that the academic community departs from its original function. It still produces knowledge, but this knowledge increasingly serves the symbolic games of the academic in-group (mutual recognition among peers) and the technical efficacy needs of the capital organ (industry collaboration), rather than the substrate components' desire to understand the world and improve their survival. According to Axiom 7, when an organ no longer performs its original function, it is alienated in the functional sense—it exists, but it is no longer a "healthy academic community," just as a heart that no longer pumps blood exists, but is no longer a "healthy heart."

Third, from the perspective of Theorem 8 (functional differentiation), when the academic community claims "I am accountable only to the state," it implicitly treats the state as an independent entity rather than a functional organ of the civilizational host. This reification conceals a crucial fact: the state organ itself can become alienated. When the state's self-organization tendency drifts from "serving the substrate components" toward "self-maintenance," serving the state is no longer equivalent to serving the public. If the academic community relinquishes its direct accountability to the substrate components and contents itself with being an appendage of the state organ, it forfeits its qualification to exist as an independent functional organ. It is no longer the "knowledge organ" of civilization; it has been reduced to a "knowledge department of the state organ." This degradation is itself an atrophy of the host body's functional differentiation—civilization loses a knowledge organ capable of independently verifying social validity, retaining only a knowledge department that serves the technical efficacy of a specific organ.

5.4 Revisiting a Key Defense: Does Specialization Inevitably Exclude the Public?

We can now more thoroughly address the defense that "specialization inevitably excludes the public."

This defense rests on a premise: the academic community is an independent professional entity, the public is another independent social entity, and the relation between them is a market relation of "service provider and consumer." In this framework, the academic community need only provide "products" (papers, patents, talent), and the public can choose to "consume" or "not consume." If the public cannot consume (cannot understand), that is a problem of consumer competence.

Theorem 8 dissolves this premise entirely. The academic community is not an external entity independent of the public, nor is the public a "consumer" of the academic community. The academic community is a functional organ of the civilizational host; the public constitutes the substrate components of that host. The relation between organ and substrate components is not a market relation; it is a relation of *existential dependence*. The heart does not need to "market" its blood-pumping service to the rest of the body; its very existence is for the purpose of serving the body. If the blood pumped by the heart cannot be effectively utilized by the rest of the body—not because the body is "too stupid," but because the heart has laced the blood with too many "specialized ingredients" that only the heart itself understands—then the problem lies with the heart, not the body.

Therefore, specialization is not the problem. The problem is that the fruits of specialization cannot be effectively utilized by the host's substrate components. This is not a cognitive failure of the public; it is a functional failure of the academic community as a knowledge organ. Conceptual suspension severs the channels through which knowledge returns to the host body, just as a blocked vessel severs the return of blood to the heart. The way to repair it is not to abolish specialized terminology (just as one does not

abolish blood), but to unblock the channels—to keep the unfolding paths of knowledge open, and to keep the channels for verifying social validity open.

5.5 Chapter Summary

This chapter established the criterion by which conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor are judged to be problems. We first distinguished the factual from the normative, arguing that Axioms 6 and 7 reveal objective regularities of systemic persistence, not moral exhortations. We then introduced Theorem 8, arguing that the academic community and the public belong to the same civilizational host as functional organ and substrate components, and that the former's responsibility to the latter is an intrinsic dependence of organ on body, not an externally imposed demand. Applying these criteria, we argued that conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor are problems because they signify the functional alienation of the academic community as a knowledge organ—a departure from original function, a blockage of knowledge returning to the host body, a failure to respond to the needs of substrate components, and a trajectory toward systemic health decline. Finally, we revisited the defense that "specialization inevitably excludes the public," arguing that the essence of the problem is not specialization itself, but the blockage of the channels through which specialized fruits can be effectively utilized by the host body.

In the next chapter, we will systematically address the other defenses of the status quo—the efficiency of terminology, the reasonableness of division of labor—and argue that the conditions under which these defenses were once valid have, in the contemporary context of a hollowed-out anchor, systematically eroded.

6. Addressing Defenses: Why Those "Reasonable" Arguments No Longer Hold

In the preceding five chapters, we introduced the diagnosis of conceptual suspension, analyzed its mechanism, traced its deep root in the hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy, and established the criterion for why this is a problem. Yet any serious diagnosis must directly confront the arguments that defend the status quo. The academic community is not without reasons for self-justification, and these reasons are internally coherent within their own logical framework. The task of this chapter is to respond to these defenses one by one, and to argue that, under the contemporary conditions of a hollowed-out anchor, the premises upon which these defenses once rested have systematically eroded.

6.1 Defense One: "Terminology Is a Necessary Tool of Efficiency"

Defense: Academic terminology exists to increase the efficiency of knowledge production. A formula in advanced mathematics can be unfolded and decomposed all the way down to basic arithmetic, but doing so would require an entire book. Terminology is a necessary cost of efficiency. To accuse terminology of making things unreadable for the public is to speak as an outsider who does not understand the regularities of knowledge production.

Response: This essay fully acknowledges the efficiency function of terminology. We do not oppose specialized terminology. What we oppose is terminology whose *unfolding path has been severed*.

A healthy terminological system is like a tree: the trunk is everyday experience, the branches are conceptual hierarchies, and the leaves are the precise terminology of cutting-edge research. One can follow the leaves back along the branches to the trunk. This requires two conditions. First, each term must have a clear unfolding path (it must be traceable back to the experiential problem to which it is

anchored). Second, at key junctures, someone must take responsibility for building staircases from ordinary language to specialized terminology. Classical academic writing did precisely this—Darwin, Freud, and Weber did not assume that their readers had already internalized their terminology; they built clear staircases within their works.

The problem with contemporary academic writing is that the unfolding paths of terminology have been systematically severed across generations of transmission. It is not terminology itself that is the problem; it is that the "packaging" of terminology has lost its "unfolding" interface. Scholars skillfully deploy terms like "alienation," "self-organization," and "agency," but if pressed to say what experiential phenomenon the term actually refers to, they may only be able to offer another term—precisely the "concept of concepts" we identified in Chapter 2.

When the unfolding path is severed, terminology ceases to be a tool of efficiency and becomes a cognitive wall. The premise of an efficiency tool is that the user knows how to use the tool and under what conditions it applies. If a term is suspended—if the scholar using it cannot themselves unfold it with precision—how does it enhance efficiency? It only enhances the efficiency of symbolic operations *within* the academic in-group, at the cost of sacrificing the return of knowledge to the host body. It is like a factory that invents an internal jargon to improve production efficiency, only for the factory's own workers to forget what the jargon originally referred to. The efficiency remains, but the direction has been lost.

Therefore, this essay does not call for the abolition of terminology. It does not demand that all papers be written for a popular audience. It only demands that the unfolding paths of terminology be restored. In every paper, core concepts should preserve an interface leading back to everyday experience. This interface need not be lengthy—a paragraph, an example, a single sentence stating "this concept was originally created to solve the following problem" is sufficient. It is not an extra burden; it is the packaging responsibility that knowledge producers ought to bear.

6.2 Defense Two: "Knowledge Dissemination Is the Job of the Education System, Not the Academic Community"

Defense: The academic community is responsible for producing knowledge; the education system is responsible for disseminating it. The division of labor is a fundamental feature of modern society. To demand that scholars also handle dissemination in their papers is an unreasonable mismatch of functions.

Response: This defense is theoretically valid, but dynamically it has already collapsed.

In an era when the rate of knowledge production was slow, this division of labor did function effectively. A scholar might produce only a handful of important papers in a lifetime, and the education system had ample time to digest, filter, and translate that knowledge into textbooks. Scholars did not need to worry about dissemination themselves, because the "next step" in the process was naturally handled by others. But in the contemporary era, when the rate of knowledge production is growing exponentially, this division of labor has broken down. Millions of papers are published globally each year, and the education system simply cannot keep up. More seriously, the education system itself has fallen into institutional inertia—textbook revision cycles are measured in decades, while the iteration cycle of frontier knowledge is measured in months. The division of labor still exists on paper, but the conveyor belt between upstream and downstream has snapped.

The consequence of this broken chain is that knowledge piles up at the production end, unable to flow effectively to the utilization end. The academic community continues to produce at high speed; the education system continues to disseminate at a glacial pace; the gap between them grows ever wider. The

public—including the highly educated public—is stranded on the far side of this chasm, unable to access knowledge directly from the academic frontier, and unable to receive a timely translated version from the education system.

Under these conditions, if the academic community continues to insist that "dissemination is someone else's job," it is refusing to take responsibility for repairing a broken chain while fully aware that it is broken. This is not division of labor; this is buck-passing. The premise of division of labor is that the chain is intact. When the chain breaks, every link in the chain has a responsibility to reach out and catch what is falling. The academic community, as the primary producer of knowledge and the one most familiar with its internal structure, is best positioned to build unfolding paths for that knowledge. This is not a demand that scholars replace teachers; it is a demand that scholars, in the act of producing knowledge, leave behind the interfaces that make dissemination possible.

6.3 Defense Three: "Industry-Academic Collaboration Already Provides Practical Verification"

Defense: The academic community is not sequestered in an ivory tower. The extensive collaboration between industry and academia—the integration of production, teaching, and research—demonstrates that academic knowledge is being tested in practice. The enterprise, as a user of knowledge, is already exercising the power of verification.

Response: This defense conflates the verification of *technical efficacy* with the verification of *social validity*. We distinguished the two in detail in Chapter 4; here we offer a brief restatement.

The enterprise verifies technical efficacy—whether this knowledge can solve a specific technical problem, improve efficiency, or generate profit. This is a legitimate and necessary form of verification, but it cannot substitute for the verification of social validity—the composite impact of this knowledge, in the course of its application, on the social members it affects.

The delivery algorithm is the paradigmatic case. The algorithm is impeccable in technical efficacy—delivery times are shortened, platform profits rise. But its social validity for delivery riders—rising accident rates, suppressed incomes, labor rhythms dictated by the system—is entirely invisible within the enterprise's verification framework. This is not because the enterprise is "deliberately ignoring" these effects; it is because the enterprise's self-organization tendency (Axiom 3) dictates that its criterion of verification is profit. To demand that the enterprise proactively verify social validity is like demanding that the heart proactively pump blood for the digestive system—that is not its function.

Therefore, industry-academic collaboration is not the *completion* of verification; it is the *localization* of verification. It narrows "the public" to "the enterprise" and "social validity" to "technical efficacy." If the academic community contents itself with this localized verification, it is like a physician who measures only the patient's blood pressure and then declares the patient to be in perfect health. The diagnosis of the hollowed-out anchor points precisely here: it is not that verification is absent, but that the dimensions of verification have been institutionally narrowed.

6.4 Defense Four: "The Public Itself Lacks the Will to Know; the Blame Cannot Fall Entirely on the Academic Community"

Defense: Papers are publicly accessible, and terminology can be looked up. If the public genuinely had the will to know, they could perfectly well go and look things up, go and learn. To place all the responsibility on the academic community while ignoring the public's own shortcomings is unfair.

Response: This defense identifies a genuine issue, but misallocates the weight of responsibility.

The public's willingness to engage in cognitive effort is indeed not unlimited. No one can invest deep

learning in every academic paper that might affect their life. To demand that the public perform "genealogical learning" on every piece of academic knowledge is unrealistic. It is like demanding that every user of a refrigerator learn the principles of refrigeration and how to repair a compressor. If a refrigerator manufacturer made such a demand, we would say that the manufacturer is shirking its responsibility.

The academic community, as the producer and packager of knowledge, has a responsibility to package knowledge into a "usable product." The refrigerator manufacturer's responsibility is to deliver a complete appliance and a user manual, not to throw a parts list at the consumer and say, "Assemble it yourself." Similarly, the academic community has a responsibility to preserve unfolding paths for its core concepts, so that members of the public who *do* have the will to know can find an entry point. The entire burden of tracing through the terminological system should not be offloaded onto the public.

This is not to say that the public bears no responsibility at all. The public needs to maintain a basic willingness to know, and needs to have the awareness that "I should try to understand" when confronted with knowledge that affects their interests. (This is part of what we call meta-cognition.) But the public's responsibility is to be *willing to enter*; the academic community's responsibility is to *open the door*. The current problem is that the academic community has not only failed to open the door, but has piled suspended concepts in the doorway, and then blames the public for "not climbing over the wall."

6.5 Defense Five: "The Classical Style of Writing Is Unrealistic Today"

Defense: The writing style of Darwin or Freud suited their era, when the total volume of knowledge was small and the readership was elite. Today, knowledge is highly specialized, and it is unrealistic to demand that every paper start from everyday experience.

Response: This essay does not demand that every paper be written like *On the Origin of Species*. It only demands that every paper preserve an *unfolding interface*.

This interface can be very brief—a mention of the problem background in the introduction, a concrete experiential case attached to the definition of a core concept, a footnote indicating the original source and original problem of a term. It need not take up much space, and it need not sacrifice professionalism. It only asks that scholars, when writing, hold in mind an "intelligent outsider" as an implied reader, and leave a window open for that reader.

This is not antiquarianism; it is basic maintenance of the cognitive contract. Just as in construction, each floor must maintain its connection to the foundation, or the building becomes unsafe, so too the edifice of academic knowledge—each paper should maintain its connection to the experiential ground. The unfolding interface is precisely that connection.

6.6 Chapter Summary

This chapter has systematically responded to five core arguments defending the status quo of academic writing. We have argued that: the efficiency function of terminology degrades into a cognitive wall when unfolding paths are severed; the division of labor between knowledge production and dissemination has become invalid in the contemporary era due to the breakdown of the transmission chain; industry-academic collaboration verifies technical efficacy, not social validity; the public's willingness to know and the academic community's packaging responsibility are complementary, not mutually exclusive; and preserving an unfolding interface is basic maintenance of the cognitive contract, not an unrealistic return to antiquated styles.

Each of these defenses, under its own premises, is valid. But under the contemporary conditions of a

hollowed-out anchor, accumulated conceptual suspension, and a broken production-dissemination chain, the conditions for their validity have systematically eroded. The academic community cannot continue to invoke these defenses to justify the status quo, because the status quo itself has departed from the picture of a "healthy division of labor" that these defenses presuppose.

In the next chapter, we will propose a way forward—not to overthrow the existing academic apparatus, but to rebuild an antagonistic structure within it, so that knowledge may once again be tested by the people.

7. Pathways to Repair: Rebuilding the Cognitive Contract Between the Academic Community and the Public

In the preceding six chapters, we completed a full argument from diagnosis to criterion. Conceptual suspension is real. Its mechanism is traceable. Its root lies in the hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy. And this hollowing out is a systemic health problem identifiable by the criteria of Axioms 6 and 7. We also addressed the core defenses of the status quo, arguing that the conditions for their validity have systematically eroded.

Now we must answer the most difficult question: *what is to be done?*

A diagnosis that stops at critique, offering no constructive path forward, is merely another form of expert complaint—refined, but impotent. This essay does not rest there. This chapter proposes a set of concrete, actionable, and testable pathways aimed at rebuilding the cognitive contract between the academic community and the public, restoring the anchor of legitimacy to its rightful mooring in the people.

The proposals in this chapter follow three guiding principles.

First, do not overthrow the existing academic apparatus; add antagonistic structures alongside it. We need not abolish peer review, eliminate specialized terminology, or turn every academic journal into a popular science magazine.

Second, do not appeal to moral exhortation; design institutional interfaces. Scholars' behavior is shaped by incentive structures. The key to repair is to change the incentive structures, not to condemn scholars for "moral decay."

Third, do not presume the omniscience of the public; provide accessible channels for those with the will to know. The public need not become experts en masse. But those social members directly affected by the application of knowledge should have an institutionalized channel through which their lived experience can feed back into knowledge production.

Based on these three principles, this chapter proposes pathways at three levels: individual writing practice, institutional design, and cognitive infrastructure.

7.1 The Level of Individual Writing Practice: Preserving the Unfolding Interface

This is the most fundamental level, and the easiest to implement immediately. It does not require waiting for institutional reform. Every scholar can begin with their very next paper.

An *unfolding interface* is, within an academic paper, a cognitive passage deliberately left open that leads from a core concept back to everyday experience. It does not require that the paper be popularized. It does not require the sacrifice of professionalism. It only requires that the scholar, when writing, hold in

mind an "intelligent outsider" as an implied reader, and leave a window open for that reader. Concretely, an unfolding interface can take any of the following forms:

Form One: Problem-Background Interface. In the introduction or the section where the concept is defined, use a short paragraph to indicate: what experiential problem was this concept originally created to solve? What typical phenomenon does it correspond to in reality? For example, a sociology paper using the concept of "alienation" might write: "The concept of alienation was originally proposed by Marx to describe a particular experience of workers in capitalist factories—tightening bolts on an assembly line day after day, not knowing what the final product is used for, feeling that one's labor is not a part of one's own life but merely a sold commodity." This passage requires no academic training to understand. It provides the reader with an experiential anchor.

Form Two: Case-Anchoring Interface. Immediately after defining a core concept, follow it with a concrete, vivid case. For example, a paper discussing "algorithmic governance" might write, after the definition: "Imagine a delivery rider. A notification pops up on their phone: the system informs them that this order must be delivered within twenty-eight minutes. This is not a manager issuing commands. It is an algorithm calculating an 'optimal solution' based on real-time traffic, restaurant preparation times, and the rider's current location. The rider has no room to negotiate—the algorithm does not get angry, but neither does it understand explanations. This is a glimpse of algorithmic governance."

Form Three: Genealogical Pointer Interface. When using an inherited concept whose precise referent has become fuzzy across generations, the author can, in a footnote or endnote, briefly indicate the concept's original source and original problem, and point the reader to where they can trace it further if they wish. This is not a demand that scholars rewrite the history of concepts in every paper, but a signpost left for those readers who wish to trace the genealogy.

Form Four: Self-Test Statement. In the introduction or methodology section, the author can use a short paragraph to perform a self-test on the paper's core concepts: What are the core concepts of this paper? Can they be pointed, in ordinary language, to concrete experiences? Are their unfolding paths clear? Such a statement is itself an inoculation against conceptual suspension—when the author is forced to ask these questions of themselves, suspended concepts have nowhere to hide.

It is crucial to emphasize that the unfolding interface is not a lowering of academic standards, but the fulfillment of academic responsibility. It takes up very little space—usually a few lines or a short paragraph suffices. It does not compromise the professionalism or rigor of the paper. It merely restores a sound tradition of classical academic writing: at the birth of a concept, preserve the umbilical cord that connects it back to experience.

7.2 The Institutional Level I: Opening a Practice-Based Verification Channel

Improvements in individual writing practice are necessary, but insufficient. The deep root of conceptual suspension lies in the hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy, and this is an institutional problem requiring an institutional response.

This section proposes the first institutional design: establishing, in parallel to the existing academic journal system, an independent *Practice-Based Verification Channel*.

Design Rationale

For any published academic paper, its conclusion section—or the "practical claims" that the author themselves extracts—may be voluntarily submitted, or submitted by a third party, to an open practice-based verification platform. On this platform, *practitioners*—those who have applied or been affected by this knowledge in the real world—may submit *practice-based verification reports*. The question that practitioners are asked to answer is not "Is this paper well-written?" but rather: "I followed the conclusions of this paper (or I was affected by the application of this research), and what actually happened?" The aim is to bring theory back to the real world for calibration.

Concrete Mechanisms

1. Submission of Verification Reports. Practitioners may be engineers, physicians, teachers, farmers, delivery riders, community workers—anyone who claims to have been affected by a piece of academic knowledge. Submitting a verification report requires real-name identification (to prevent malicious spamming) and requires a description of the specific practice context and the observed outcomes.

2. Review of Verification Reports. The platform performs only basic review—whether the report contains personal attacks, whether it is manifestly irrelevant, whether it is machine-generated. The review does not assess whether the report's conclusions are "correct," nor whether the report "supports" or "opposes" the original paper. Successful verifications and failed verifications hold equal value.

3. Presentation of Verification Reports. On the page for each verified paper, all practice-based verification reports are aggregated. Readers can see: in how many practice contexts this specialized academic knowledge has been tested, and what effects were observed in each. The platform does not provide a single "composite score." Instead, it presents multi-dimensional raw information—the number of verifications, the diversity of verifiers (across different regions and backgrounds), the information richness of the reports (plain text or with accompanying data), the proportion of long-term follow-ups, and the ratio of positive to negative outcomes. Readers can filter and sort according to the dimensions they care about.

4. Linkage to Academic Evaluation. In the initial phase, the practice-based verification channel exists as "supplementary information" for papers and does not affect traditional academic evaluation. In the medium term, exploration can begin on incorporating practice-based verification metrics as reference indicators in grant applications and promotion reviews. In the long term, practice-based verification may become a core dimension in assessing the social validity of research.

On Verification Formats: Let Standards Emerge from Use

A natural question arises: what format should practice-based verification reports follow? Who sets the standard?

The answer of this essay is: *no one sets the standard. Standards emerge from use.*

In its early stages, the platform provides only a minimal reference suggestion: "Please describe what knowledge you applied, in what context you applied it, and what outcomes you observed." This suggestion is not a mandatory template. Early verifiers submit reports according to their own understanding. Those reports that are informationally complete, logically clear, and well-supported by evidence will naturally receive more "helpful" feedback from readers. Later verifiers, seeing these reports, will spontaneously imitate their format—not because the platform mandates it, but because such formats have proven more effective in persuading readers.

Different fields may see different mainstream formats emerge. Education may emphasize

"implementation duration" and "student feedback." Technology may emphasize "performance parameters" and "failure rates." These formats are not "set" by anyone; they are consensus forms spontaneously generated by practitioners in a given field through repeated verification. They are not standards; they are merely widely referenced exemplars.

Crucially, formats themselves remain forever in evolution. Any verifier may add new information dimensions to their report. If a new dimension proves effective (readers indicate "this information was useful to me"), it will be adopted by later verifiers; if ineffective, it will be naturally eliminated in practice. The platform never solidifies any format as a "mandatory standard." Mainstream formats merely lower decision costs for newcomers; they do not constitute a barrier against new formats.

On Verifier Credibility: Let Trust Emerge from History

An equally natural question is: how does one judge whether a verifier is credible?

The answer, again, is: *no one has the authority to certify credibility. Credibility emerges from the historical record.*

The platform grants no verifier any "certification" or "rank." The platform merely faithfully presents each verifier's public history: how many verification reports they have submitted, how many "helpful" feedbacks those reports have received from other independent individuals, what the domain distribution of those reports is, and whether they report negative outcomes as faithfully as positive ones.

When a reader views a verification report, they can click on the verifier's name and examine their historical record. A verifier who has long submitted high-quality reports, faithfully reported negative outcomes, and accumulated rich practical experience in a specific domain will naturally see their opinion accorded greater weight—not weight assigned by the platform, but weight that each independent reader, upon viewing the historical record, decides for themselves to grant. The platform merely makes these distributed judgments visible, without substituting its own judgment for anyone else's.

On Manipulation Risks: Let Information Be Multi-Dimensional

If there is no centralized review or certification, how can manipulation be prevented—for instance, someone organizing a flood of fake verification reports to inflate or deflate the evaluation of a piece of knowledge?

The answer is: *make information multi-dimensional, rather than relying on any single metric.*

The platform does not provide a single "approval rating" or "composite score." It presents multi-dimensional raw information: the quantity of verification reports, the diversity of verifiers, the information richness of the reports, the proportion of long-term follow-ups, and the ratio of positive to negative outcomes. Readers can filter and sort along whichever dimensions they care about. This multi-dimensionality dilutes the payoff of manipulation—a manipulator may be able to inflate one dimension, but cannot easily inflate all dimensions simultaneously.

More importantly, the platform itself can serve as an open data source, allowing any third party to develop their own ranking algorithms and analytical tools. If the platform's default presentation is accused of bias, anyone can develop an alternative based on the raw data.

On Initial Chaos: Provide Optional References, Not Mandatory Standards

A practical concern is that in the early stages, without a unified template, verification report formats will be wildly varied, making lateral comparison difficult for readers and potentially leading to low platform usage.

The response is: the platform can collect early high-quality reports and display them as "reference examples," but clearly label them: "These examples are for reference only; you may submit in any format." This lowers decision costs for newcomers while imposing no mandate. Reference examples are not standards; they are merely signposts that reduce the cost of exploration.

Why This Will Not Lead to Chaos

A natural worry is: won't an open verification channel devolve into "populist voting"? Won't people who don't understand the field leave random evaluations?

This worry rests on a misunderstanding—it assumes that practice-based verification is "the public voting on whether a paper is good or bad." In fact, practice-based verification is not voting; it is the provision of *evidence based on lived experience*. A verification report submitted by a delivery rider is not a "review" of an algorithm paper; it is a factual statement: "This is what my work experience is like under the management of this algorithm." A verification report submitted by a farmer is not a "professional evaluation" of an agricultural technology; it is a factual statement: "After using this technology, this is what happened to my yield and income." Such evidence does not require professional review qualifications, because it does not judge the internal validity of the paper; it merely provides a data point on social validity. In essence, this is *feedback based on factual verification*, not professional peer review. Crucially, the practice-based verification channel is *open but not mandatory*. A purely theoretical paper may have no practice-based verification reports at all, and this does not affect its academic value. But if a policy study that claims to improve educational equity is repeatedly verified in practice as ineffective or even harmful, those verification reports should be visible to subsequent policy-makers. The value of the practice-based verification channel is not to assign grades to papers, but to ensure that *silent evidence no longer remains silent*.

Boundary Statement: What This Mechanism Solves, and What It Does Not

The design goal of the practice-based verification channel is not "to create a perfect system for testing knowledge," but "to rebuild the verification channel for *social validity* within academic knowledge production." It addresses the "missing verification channel" link in the problem of the hollowed-out anchor.

It does *not* solve the following problems:

- **The public's unwillingness to exercise the power of verification.** If the public generally lacks the will to know, even the best channel will remain empty. This is the responsibility of the education system, public culture, and the cultivation of meta-cognition, not something this mechanism alone can address.
- **The absolute authenticity of verification reports.** No mechanism can completely eliminate fake reports, just as no mechanism can completely eliminate academic fraud. The practice-based verification channel does not pursue "absolute fraud-proofing," but instead raises the cost and lowers the benefit of fake reports through multi-dimensional information and historical accumulation.
- **The verification of highly technical knowledge.** For knowledge that exceeds the comprehension of ordinary people, the social validity verification of the practice-based channel is limited. The social validity verification of such knowledge requires reliance on independent professional bodies—and those bodies themselves should also be subject to verification through the practice-based channel. This is the recursion of antagonism, not a design flaw of this

mechanism.

The Theoretical Foundation of This Design

This design directly derives from the insights of System Topology concerning "discrete structures." The pyramidal structure within the academic community (peer review, journal rankings) is necessary—it safeguards the internal validity and efficiency of knowledge production. But a healthy system cannot consist solely of pyramidal structures; it also requires the antagonism of discrete structures. The practice-based verification channel is precisely a discrete structure: no center, no authority, no mandatory standards. Order is not designed; it emerges from the local interactions of countless distributed individuals.

This is precisely the application of **Meta-Axiom Zero: The Principle of Self-Organization Tendency** at the level of institutional design: order can spontaneously arise from local interactions without a central designer. The platform's role is not "designer" but "ecological steward"—maintaining the neutrality of rules, the transparency of information, and the openness of interfaces, and then letting order grow itself.

7.3 The Institutional Level II: Opening a Public Submission Channel

The second institutional design is: establishing, in parallel to the existing academic journal system, a *Public Submission Channel*.

Design Rationale

Currently, the channels for publishing academic papers are entirely monopolized by the academic apparatus. A person without academic credentials—even if they possess important practical discoveries—cannot publish an academic paper through formal channels. This not only excludes knowledge producers from outside the academy, but also deprives the academic community of a vital source of knowledge. The Public Submission Channel aims to break this monopoly, restoring knowledge production as a public activity in which *anyone who follows basic norms can participate*.

Concrete Mechanisms

1. Submission and Review. Anyone may submit a paper. The platform performs only basic review—whether the format follows norms (title, abstract, body, references), whether the content involves illegal or hate speech, whether it is a duplicate submission. There is no peer review. Papers that pass basic review are publicly posted.

2. Visibility Mechanisms. The visibility of a paper is not determined by editors, but by the following factors: practice-based verification metrics (see Section 7.2), reader feedback ("this paper was useful/not useful to me"), and citation patterns (cited by other public-submission papers or by academic papers). Good papers naturally rise; poor papers naturally sink.

3. Interface with the Academic System. In the initial phase, the Public Submission Channel operates in parallel with the academic system. In the medium term, a "certification" mechanism may be established—papers that perform exceptionally well in the Public Submission Channel may be selected for republication by academic journals, or their authors may be invited to participate in academic dialogues. In the long term, the Public Submission Channel may become a legitimate component of academic knowledge production, complementing the peer-review system.

Why This Will Not Lead to "Bad Money Driving Out Good"

A natural worry is: without peer review, won't a flood of junk papers bury the truly valuable work?

This worry overlooks a crucial fact: *writing a paper is itself a threshold activity*. Formulating a question, organizing an argument, citing evidence—this set of skills requires training. The practitioners who are genuinely capable of writing valuable papers have typically already accumulated rich knowledge in their own domains; they simply lack academic credentials and publication channels. The Public Submission Channel opens the door for them, but it does not suddenly cause a flood of "cranks" to appear outside the door—because those who can walk through the door must themselves possess a certain cognitive capacity. More importantly, the visibility mechanism serves as a natural filter. Junk papers, once submitted, receive no practice-based verifications, no "useful" feedback from readers, and no citations—they simply sink into silence. They are not "deleted"; they are merely marginalized by the natural flow of information.

7.4 The Level of Cognitive Infrastructure: Making Verification Routine

Individual practice and institutional channels require the support of cognitive infrastructure.

Infrastructure One: A Concept Genealogy Database. Establish an open, traceable database of academic concepts. Each entry for a concept contains: the original proposer, the original text, the original definition, the original problem, key nodes of evolution, and classic cases. When a reader encounters an unfamiliar term in a paper, they can use this database to quickly trace its origins, without having to drown in a sea of literature.

Infrastructure Two: Public Education in Meta-Cognition. Within the public education system, systematically cultivate citizens' meta-cognitive abilities—the ability to recognize cognitive frameworks, trace the origins of concepts, and test knowledge claims. This is not a demand that everyone become a scholar; it is a demand that everyone, when confronted with knowledge that affects their own interests, be able to ask the right questions: *What does this term mean? Where did it come from? Does it apply in my context? Who has tested it?* This ability is the cognitive prerequisite for the public to exercise the power of verification.

7.5 Addressing Foreseeable Objections

Objection One: "This plan is too idealistic. Who is going to actually do it?"

This objection conflates "idealistic" with "unrealistic." The pathways proposed in this essay do not require waiting for a perfect institutional design to be imposed from the top down. *Unfolding interfaces*—any scholar can begin with their very next paper. *Practice-based verification channel*—can be piloted in a single discipline, a single field, or on a single open-source platform. *Public submission channel*—can operate initially as an independent website, accumulating case studies before seeking integration with the academic system. This is not a utopian blueprint that is "all or nothing." It is a set of concrete measures that can be implemented incrementally and tested step by step.

Objection Two: "Does this plan not deny the value of peer review?"

No. Peer review holds irreplaceable value in testing the *internal validity* of research. The proposal of this essay is not to abolish peer review, but to *supplement* it. Peer review tests whether methods are rigorous and reasoning is coherent; practice-based verification tests whether knowledge holds up in terms of *social validity*. The two are not substitutes; they are antagonists. A healthy academic ecology requires the simultaneous presence and mutual counterbalance of both internal validity verification and social

validity verification.

7.6 Chapter Summary

This chapter has proposed pathways at three levels for rebuilding the cognitive contract between the academic community and the public. At the level of individual writing practice, scholars can preserve unfolding interfaces, building staircases from core concepts down to everyday experience. At the institutional level, the practice-based verification channel allows the lived experience of affected parties to become evidence testing social validity, while the public submission channel allows excluded knowledge producers to re-enter the arena of public verification. At the level of cognitive infrastructure, the concept genealogy database and public education in meta-cognition provide the underlying support. This set of proposals does not overthrow the existing apparatus, but adds antagonistic structures alongside it; does not appeal to moral exhortation, but designs institutional interfaces; does not presume the omniscience of the public, but provides accessible channels for those with the will to know. It is not a utopian blueprint, but a set of concrete measures that can be implemented incrementally and tested step by step.

In the next and final chapter—the conclusion of this essay—we will review the entire argument and clarify how this essay itself has attempted to exemplify what it advocates.

8. Conclusion: Let "Ping" Be Duckweed Again

Eight chapters ago, we set out from a question: why have "experts" become "brick-throwers"? Why do those who have received the finest education utter statements that so flagrantly defy common sense?

Eight chapters later, we have an answer: because concepts have become suspended, and the anchor of legitimacy has been hollowed out.

Conceptual suspension is the phenomenon whereby an academic concept, transmitted across generations, retains its name while its referent drifts. It requires no one to make a mistake; it only requires that each generation of scholars write from literature, not from problems, that they fail to unfold their concepts, that they neglect to anchor them in experience. Error accumulates quietly across generations. *The hollowing out of the anchor of legitimacy* is the institutional exclusion of the academic community's rightful validator—the public—from the apparatus of verification. Peers test internal validity; capital tests technical efficacy. But the verifier of *social validity*—those people directly affected by the application of knowledge—has no institutionalized channel to feed their lived experience back into knowledge production.

Conceptual suspension and the hollowed-out anchor are two sides of the same coin. Suspended concepts inflate the cognitive cost for the public to access knowledge; the hollowed-out anchor blocks the institutional channel for the public to test it. Together, they disable the navigation system of the academic community. The ship still sails; knowledge is still produced. But its course is no longer set by its original function. It is steered instead by the symbolic games of the peer circle and the technical efficacy demands of capital.

This is not moral corruption. It is a systemic inevitability. Each generation of scholars does what is "correct." Yet correct operations, accumulated, yield an erroneous outcome.

The path forward is not to overthrow the existing apparatus. Peer review must be retained; specialized terminology must be retained; the verification of internal validity must be retained. The path forward is to *add antagonistic structures* alongside the existing apparatus—to rebuild channels through which the

public can test knowledge. Unfolding interfaces restore the anchoring of concepts in experience. The practice-based verification channel restores the testing of social validity. The public submission channel allows excluded knowledge producers to re-enter the arena of public verification.

This is not a utopian blueprint. It is a set of concrete measures that can be implemented incrementally and tested step by step. Any scholar can begin preserving unfolding interfaces with their very next paper. Any discipline, any field, any open-source platform can begin piloting a practice-based verification channel. The public submission channel can operate initially as an independent website, accumulating case studies before seeking integration with the academic system.

The Self-Test of This Essay

An essay that diagnoses conceptual suspension must submit itself to the test for conceptual suspension. An essay that argues knowledge should be subject to public scrutiny must submit itself to public scrutiny. Here, then, is the self-test of this essay.

The core concepts of this essay are *conceptual suspension*, *anchor of legitimacy*, and *unfolding path*. Are they suspended?

Conceptual suspension was anchored in Section 2.1 through the thought experiment of the character "苹," given a formal definition in Section 2.2, and illustrated through the engineering analogy of error accumulation in Section 2.3. The reader can trace this concept back to its experiential referent from any of these interfaces.

Anchor of legitimacy was anchored in Section 4.1 through the metaphor of a ship's navigation system, and unfolded in Section 4.2 through the mechanism of the double barrier. The reader can clearly trace what this concept refers to: the external validator upon which a subsystem's legitimacy depends.

Unfolding path was explicitly defined in Section 3.2 as "the cognitive chain that traces a specialized concept back to the experiential problem to which it was originally anchored," and has been repeatedly demonstrated throughout this essay. In reading this essay, the reader has been experiencing the meaning of "unfolding path"—each core concept has been provided with a staircase down to everyday experience. The mode of argument in this essay is not "literature-first" but "problem-first." Its starting point is not a gap in the scholarly literature, but a publicly observable phenomenon: experts becoming brick-throwers. Its argument is anchored in phenomena that any literate person can verify for themselves: the unreadability of academic papers, the common-sense-defying pronouncements of experts, the blind spots of social validity in industry-academic collaboration.

This essay has assumed no prior internalization of academic jargon. Every term has been accompanied, upon first use, by an unfolding interface. This essay invites every reader to test its claims against their own lived experience—just as the practice-based verification channel invites practitioners to test academic knowledge.

If this essay has failed this test—if you have found its core concepts suspended and anchorless, its argumentative chain broken, its conclusions unmoored from everyday experience—then the failure belongs to the essay, not to the reader.

Let "Ping" Be Duckweed Again

Let us return, one last time, to that character "苹."

The first generation of scholars used "苹" to refer to duckweed. They wrote down the definition, anchored it in experience. The second generation cited it directly, assuming readers knew. The fifth generation used it to describe cultural drift—the signifier remained, the signified had drifted. The tenth generation

wrote the character "苹" without knowing whether it originally meant duckweed or apple.

Conceptual suspension is this very process. It is not conspiracy. It is not corruption. It is merely the cumulative consequence of correct operations.

But there is something we can do: *each time we use a concept, preserve an umbilical cord back to experience*. When defining "苹," tell the reader: it originally referred to a small green plant floating on the surface of water, roots suspended beneath, commonly found in southern paddy fields. This sentence requires no academic training to understand. It takes perhaps ten seconds to write. But it allows "苹" to be duckweed again. It allows the concept to be anchored once more in experiential ground.

This is the final plea of this essay.

Not to overthrow the academic apparatus. Not to abolish specialized terminology. Not to write popular science in every paper.

Only this: *at the birth of a concept, preserve the umbilical cord back to experience*.

Only this: *let the channels for testing the social validity of knowledge be open to the people*.

Only this: *let "ping" be duckweed again*.

Appendix A: Glossary of Core Terms

This glossary provides concise definitions of the core terms employed in this essay. Each term is accompanied by a reference to the section where it is first introduced and anchored.

- **Conceptual Suspension**

The phenomenon whereby an academic concept, transmitted across generations, retains its stable signifier while its signified undergoes cumulative drift due to the severance of its unfolding path, rendering the concept incapable of being traced back with precision to its original experiential anchor. (Section 2.2)

- **Anchor of Legitimacy**

The ultimate validator to which a subsystem's legitimacy is moored—the agent capable of defining the subsystem's mode of self-organization through the exercise of its rights. For the academic community, its original anchor of legitimacy is the public. (Section 4.1)

- **Unfolding Path / Unfolding Interface**

The cognitive chain that traces a specialized concept back to the experiential problem and everyday phenomenon to which it was originally anchored. An *unfolding interface* is a deliberate opening left by the writer that allows the reader to step back down to the ground of lived experience. (Section 3.2)

- **Technical Efficacy**

The effectiveness of a piece of knowledge or technology in solving a specified technical problem. Its typical verifier is the enterprise. (Section 4.2.3)

- **Social Validity**

The composite impact of a piece of knowledge or technology, in the course of its application, on the social members it affects. Its verifier should be those affected parties themselves. (Section 4.2.3)

- **Self-Organization Tendency**

The inherent propensity of any system to maintain and expand itself. The academic community possesses its own self-organization tendency. (Axiom 3; introduced in Section 4.1)

- **Functional Differentiation and the Reification Fallacy**

The error of mistaking the functionally differentiated organs of a civilizational host (such as the

state, capital, or the academic community) for independent external entities. (Theorem 8; Section 5.2)

- **Practice-Based Verification Channel**

An open platform, parallel to existing academic journals, where practitioners affected by the application of knowledge can submit verification reports, providing evidence of a knowledge claim's social validity in real-world contexts. (Section 7.2)

- **Public Submission Channel**

A channel that breaks the credential monopoly on academic publication, allowing anyone who follows basic scholarly norms to submit a paper and have it filtered by practical verification rather than peer review alone. (Section 7.3)

- **Cognitive Contract**

The implicit contract between the academic community and the public, by which the former produces and disseminates reliable knowledge in service of the cognitive development of the latter. (Introduction)

- **Problem-First vs. Literature-First**

Two paradigms of academic writing. *Problem-first* begins from a genuine experiential perplexity and creates or refines concepts to address it. *Literature-first* begins from gaps in the existing textual record and inherits concepts without rebuilding their unfolding paths. (Section 3.1)

- **Concept of Concepts**

A characteristic operation of suspended academic writing: explaining concepts with other concepts in a self-referential loop, with no link ever touching experiential ground. (Section 2.5)

Appendix B: Theoretical Background

This essay draws upon axioms and theorems from the author's broader theoretical framework of System Ontology and Noetic Ecology. The foundational axioms cited in this essay are:

Axiom 3: The Principle of Self-Organization Tendency

Any system exhibits an inherent, intrinsic tendency to maintain and expand its own ordered structure. In noetic systems, this tendency manifests as a drive toward self-preservation and expansion of cognitive frameworks.

Axiom 6: The Criterion of Human-Centered Value

The persistence of any social system depends on its ability to continuously satisfy the specific needs of its internal components, thereby maintaining their coordinated participation. Systemic value is expressed as the efficacy of its response to the needs of its components.

Axiom 7: The Principle of Functional Derivation

The sole legitimacy for the emergence and existence of any subsystem within a social system derives from its original function of serving the overall health of the host system.

Theorem 8: Functional Differentiation and the Reification Fallacy

In any noetic system that has reached a certain degree of complexity, there exist no "external entities" independent of the host system. All phenomena identified as "capital," "the state," "the market," and so forth, are functional differentiations that have emerged from the host system to fulfill specific functional needs. They are organs of the host system, not independent game-players. (Introduced in this essay; to be incorporated into future revisions of *System Ontology*.)

The full theoretical framework is developed across the following works by the author:

- **System Ontology** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19353224) — The meta-theoretical layer, providing the ultimate jurisprudence of existence and the axiomatic foundation.
- **Noetic Ecology** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19353340) — The general theoretical layer, investigating the laws of cognitive, cultural, and social systems.
- **Civilization Dynamics** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19353434) — The applied theoretical layer, extending the framework to civilizational diagnosis and design.
- **Introduction to Cognitive Protocols** (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19448172) — An entry-point work deducing core concepts from disciplinary consensus foundations.

All works are freely available at the author's personal repository: <https://github.com/wenhe1994/wenhe001>

Further Reading and Academic Context

The argument of this essay is rooted in a broader intellectual ecology. The following notes are provided not to assert academic legitimacy, but to offer signposts for readers who wish to trace these ideas further.

Classical Intellectual Resources

- **Marx, K.** *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844* (the section on "Estranged Labor"). This essay's distinction between technical efficacy and social validity inherits and transforms Marx's insight into the separation of the worker from the product of labor.
- **Weber, M.** *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (Chapters 1–2). Weber showed how ideas shape institutions; this essay asks how academic writing's "calling" drifted from serving the public to serving peers.
- **Darwin, C.** *On the Origin of Species* (Chapter 1, "Variation Under Domestication"). Darwin's method of beginning from the concrete experience of pigeon breeders exemplifies the "problem-first" paradigm.
- **Kuhn, T.S.** *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chapters 2–5). Kuhn described how paradigms govern normal science; this essay asks how paradigms themselves lose experiential anchorage through conceptual suspension.

Contemporary Empirical Precedents

- **Open Peer Review Experiments:** *Nature's* open peer review trials since 2006, and platforms like *eLife* and *F1000Research*, which make review processes transparent and traceable. The practice-based verification channel proposed in this essay extends this direction from "peers" to "all practitioners affected by knowledge."
- **Citizen Science:** Platforms like *Zooniverse* (www.zooniverse.org) engage millions of volunteers in authentic scientific data collection and analysis. The public submission channel proposed in this essay represents a cognitive upgrade of this movement: participation not only in data collection, but in the verification of knowledge claims and the production of papers.
- **Algorithmic Governance and Labor:** Reports by labor NGOs on the working conditions of platform delivery riders provide first-hand evidence of the social validity (or lack thereof) of algorithmic systems. These reports are real-world precursors of the "practice-based verification reports" this essay advocates.
- **Concept Genealogy Prototypes:** The *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (plato.stanford.edu) provides expert-authored entries that include historical origins, key evolutionary nodes, classic debates, and contemporary applications. The "Concept Genealogy Database" envisioned in this essay can be seen as an extension of this model from philosophy to all academic concepts, and from expert authorship to community collaboration.

This list is not exhaustive. It merely opens a few windows for the interested reader. True intellectual dialogue is never completed within the confines of a reference list.